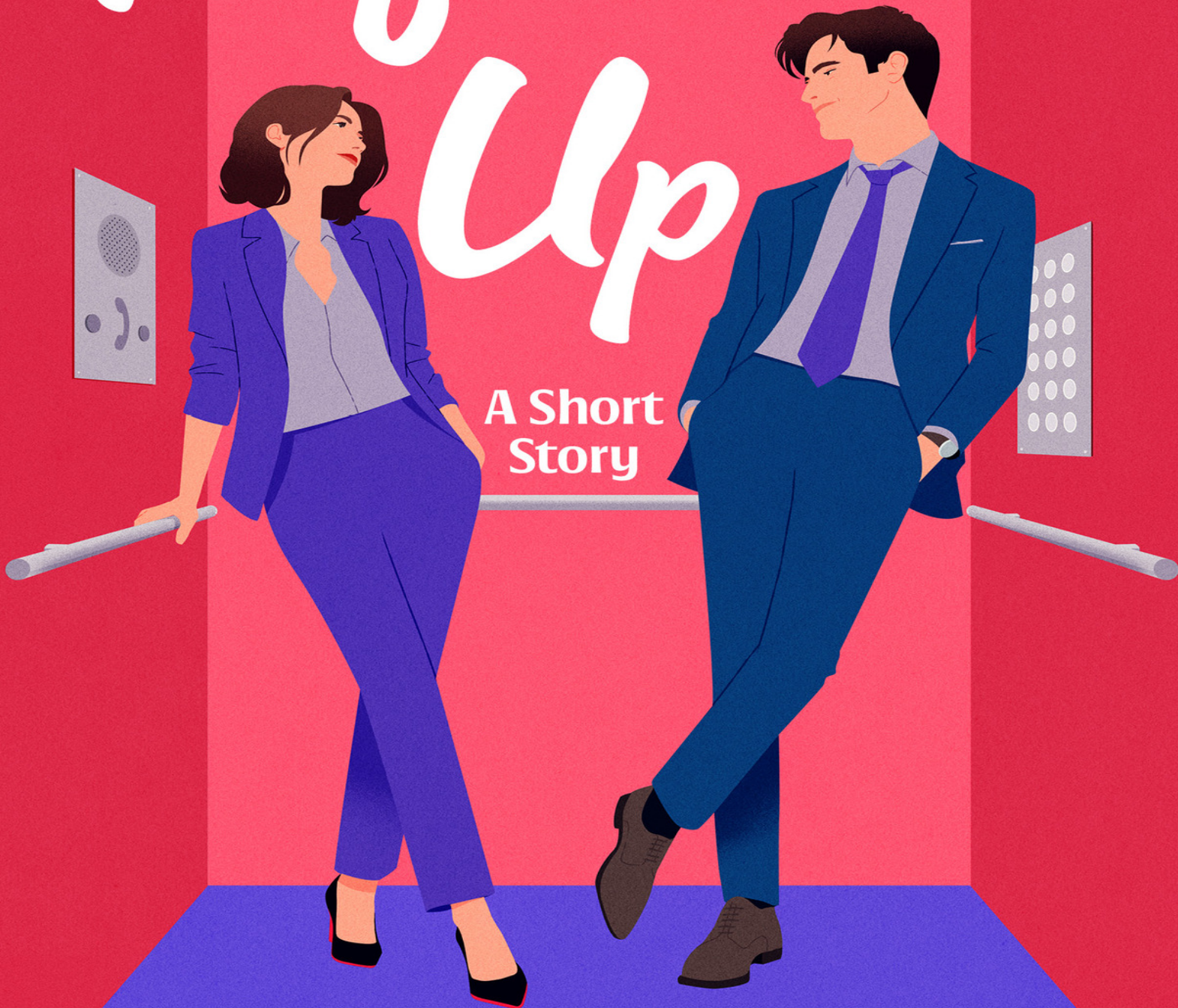


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Lift Me Up

A Short Story

MILLY JOHNSON

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To all lovers of romantic fiction. Never let anyone tell you that just because a book has a happy ending, it is somehow 'lesser'. Enjoy being filled with hope and positivity, relish the rush of endorphins and dopamine, dare to dream that life might throw some fabulous curveballs at you too. And be as proud to read romfic as I am to write it.

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PART 1

THE LIFT

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May – The Beginning

He would not have been number one on Tam Remington's list to be stuck in a lift with. In fact, he would have been way down the list, possibly hitting triple figures.

Jack Cesaroni. The man who had stolen her job. A job that was much more than a job to her because she loved it, she was good at it, she had earned it, *and* she was doing it. But in the end the board had decided that someone with 'more experience' would be better suited to running the shop. They, of course, meant by that: 'a man', because they were fusty old men who had built a female-resistant glass ceiling over their company, and if they hadn't been so desperate to steady their ship in the wake of disaster, they wouldn't have given Tam even a temporary look-in.

Today, Tam's stress levels were high enough without *this* happening because she was travelling up to her own execution in the worst mode of transport available. Lifts did something to her gut. Especially the lifts in this place – small, claustrophobic, upright coffins, which she rarely used because it was too easy to imagine the brushed-metal walls beginning to shift inwards ready to crush her, horror-film style. *Six . . . seven . . .* each floor the lift cleared was taking her closer to the end of her time at YorkMart Supermarkets. Hadn't Jack said that's what would be happening? Well, not in so many words, but his meaning was beyond clear.

Nine . . . ten

Tam felt sick.

Eleven . . . twelve

And then it happened. In between floors thirteen (had to be, didn't it?) and fourteen of Crown Tower. That's when the lift made a horrific squeaking noise, a violent judder, and all the lights went off. Tam heard a high-pitched shriek, and it took her a delayed few seconds to realise it came from her own throat. Panic rose in her that didn't abate when the dim emergency lights came on.

'Are you all right?' asked Jack.

And Tam wasn't sure if her snapped reply – 'No. How can I be all right?' – was said aloud or only in her own head.

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Chapter 1

FEBRUARY – THREE MONTHS AGO

Martin Middlewood, MD of YorkMart Supermarkets, resigned his position in the same manner that he had run the company: like an ineffectual, irresponsible wimp.

As the saying sort of goes, if brains were dynamite, he wouldn't have had enough to stir his own nasal hairs. He had kept up the charade of being in control far longer than Tam had expected. But finally, realising that Mr Shit was about to hit Mrs Fan, he did a moonlight flit. He walked out of his office at 5 p.m. on a freezing February Friday night, leaving a note on his desk to say that he'd quit, he couldn't cope, he wouldn't be back and any attempt to contact him would be viewed as harassment. It was only then, when they finally started to try and mop up the mess, that the board realised they were in dire straits more than Mark Knopfler was. And that upset Tam more than she could say because she had seen through Middlewood for a long time, but did anyone listen to her reservations and doubts? Nope. No one. And the result was a company culture of overvalued managers, undervalued personnel, morale and profits at an all-time low, with the mission statement of *Quality First Always* consigned to a skip.

But after the Middlewood fiasco, the board were desperate to keep the shareholders sweet and they finally found they needed her: this woman who had foreseen all that would happen. She knew they'd resolved to appoint a 'Messiah' who would undo all the damage and restore faith in the company for the shareholders, but in the meantime they'd appoint someone to hold the fort. And that someone was Tam Remington. She was determined to blind them with her shine. She knew YorkMart inside out; they would find no better. At night, lying in bed, she visualised her future, willing it to manifest: the board realising her brilliance and declaring: *My goodness. Why are we even looking for anyone else when we have Tam Remington in the big chair? Let's double her pay immediately and worship her.* The big soft leather MD's chair felt wonderful under her bottom, like a queen's on

her rightful throne. But not even that would be a patch on telling her family about it. She couldn't wait for the next Sunday lunch, which, as luck would have it, was a mere few days away.

On the first Sunday of every month, Tam's family gathered at the family home for an elaborate roast. In the long run-up to her June wedding, this had increased in regularity, with the invitation extended to her fiancé Harris's mother, Davina Bullivant, and Tam's best friend, Natasha, who also happened to be Harris's twin. Tam's mother, Samantha, was a superb cook and seized any opportunity to show off her culinary skills. They had a table in their dining room long enough to accommodate a state banquet if needs be. Ironically, that's what it always felt like too – more formal than informal, best manners at the ready. Absolutely no elbows.

Tam's brother, Jame, always brought along his long-term girlfriend, Meredith, who hardly said a word. Sometimes, Tam couldn't even remember if she was present or not, she was so invisible. Her sister, Hellen, had never brought a partner to lunch. Tam wasn't sure if she'd ever had one. If she had, she'd probably eaten them after sex.

The moment of revelation fell beautifully into her lap. Jame started waxing lyrical about a boat he had his eye on buying, not because he was passionate about sailing, but because owning one would impress people. Hellen, a barrister, counteracted with a boast of her own about a case she'd won, eviscerating the defence witnesses, and then her father, Thomas, shouted down the table, as a joke: 'Anything you'd like to add to the family achievements, Tamantha?' There was a hic of laughter from Jame before Tam swallowed in preparation and then said,

'Not really, unless you count being installed as MD of YorkMart.'

Jame almost choked on his pork loin.

'Good one,' said Hellen with a snort.

'Really?' was all her brother contributed, when he'd regained his composure.

'I'd hardly lie,' Tam replied.

'Well, you did once lie that you'd landed the part of Cinderella in the school play,' supplied Hellen, and Tam's face distorted into incredulity.

Was that the best her sister could drum up as a response: the lie-that-wasn't-a-lie incident that happened when she was ten? The teacher had announced the cast list to the class and said, *Tamantha Remington will play Cinderella and Bernice Mason will be one of the chorus*, which Tam had

taken as gospel. But Bernice's father had put a lot of money into the school coffers and there was an abrupt change of the *dramatis personae*. The teacher was very apologetic and beefed up Tam's role in the chorus, but a non-speaking-part waltz with Prince Charming's assistant Dandini did nothing to lessen her disappointment. Her sister, though, had preferred to believe she'd out and out lied. She never had been one for giving anybody the benefit of the doubt.

Then Harris backed her up, which was nice because when Tam had first told him about the promotion he'd not whooped as she'd really wanted him to. He'd used the excuse that he was just shocked into silence, but Tam had wondered for the slightest moment if he had been a tad jealous, something for which she felt immediately guilty. As if.

'It's true. Tam is the new acting MD of YorkMart as from this week.' But he'd used the word she had deliberately omitted because she knew it would leap out, become the focus word. And she was right.

'Ah, *acting*,' said Hellen.

'Well, still . . . excellent, I suppose. Even if it's only temporary,' said Thomas.

Davina and Samantha exchanged glances and Tam wondered what all that was about.

'Good job I'm not an *acting* surgeon,' guffawed Jame in response, gesturing with his glass of claret pompously. 'Especially this week, when I had a particularly challenging surgery on a detached retina.' With that, he sucked all the attention his way. And Tam's big moment disappeared as quickly as it had come.

Later, when Tam nipped to the loo, passing by the kitchen where Harris and his mother were in the process of clearing away the lunch things, she heard something that made her hang around the door and eavesdrop.

'What on earth is she thinking of?' asked Davina in the sort of whisper that could never really be a whisper for someone who spoke so naturally loudly all the time. 'You do both realise that there is a high likelihood of you having twins when the babies come along.'

'Yes, of course we realise this,' said Harris.

‘And Tamantha will have to give up her job to look after them, of course, so why on earth is she pursuing promotion?’

‘Don’t worry, Mum, when the children . . .’

But Tam didn’t hear the rest because Meredith rounded the corner with a stack of plates and she had to abandon her spying. She only hoped that Harris had put his mother right and told her that it wasn’t any of her business what would happen when – or if – children came along.

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Chapter 2

THE LIFT

Jack spoke down the emergency phone in the lift and Tam listened in to his half of the conversation.

‘An hour? Really? . . . Ah, I see. Well, I don’t see as if we can do anything other than wait, can we? Thank you.’ He was calm, polite, as he put the phone back on the cradle. ‘They said to sit tight and they’re sending a crew round. So we shouldn’t really attempt the hatch and climb up the cables.’ He pointed to the small square trapdoor above their heads. ‘I am joking, by the way.’

The noise of Tam’s breathing was filling the lift. She could hear her own lungs operating like a battered accordion, complete with whistling wheeze. And her inhaler was in the desk drawer because she hadn’t anticipated she’d need it merely going up a few floors in a lift. Just brilliant.

‘I suppose we should make ourselves comfortable, Tam, what do you think?’ Jack folded his legs beneath him and sat on the floor of the lift and Tam thought she’d better follow suit. For one thing, she didn’t fancy standing in one place in these ridiculous Louboutin heels she had worn to give her some confidence to get through today. All they ever threatened to give her was pain and eventual bunions. She lowered herself as gracefully as she could, which wasn’t easy in this black pencil-skirted suit. A present from Harris, something to wear and look smart and businesslike in, he’d said when he presented it to her, though she felt a frump in it really.

She sat with her spine straightened by tension, her eyes forward, her breathing jagged.

‘So . . . tell me about how you came to work for YorkMart,’ said Jack.

Tam’s eyes shifted round to him in disbelief that he was trying to engage her in conversation when she was clearly in a state.

‘Beats the silence,’ he said, with a shrug.

Tam grabbed a breath, humoured him.

‘I’d just graduated. Ten years ago. Business Studies. First-class honours.’ Tam wasn’t usually prone to bragging, but she wanted him to know she was no teacake. ‘I walked in here and I just knew this was the place I wanted to be.’

‘Why?’

‘There was a buzz, a vibe, an energy. It was like being in the pull of a power station,’ replied Tam, aware of how airy-fairy that sounded, but it was nevertheless true. ‘It was the youngest and smallest of all the supermarkets, but it had great potential. I was right to trust my instincts. Back then, I was part of a keen dream team of like-minded people. It was a great place to work.’

‘Was?’ He drew attention to the use of the past tense.

‘Yes.’ She replied with emphasis but without elaboration.

‘And you rose through the ranks.’

She’d been justly rewarded for her efforts, until the then MD retired and Martin Middlewood took over. Then her career path stalled. Middlewood had greased his way into top position; the board were well and truly taken in and promoted him way beyond his abilities, and he only wanted his own people around him: an all-male comfort blanket.

‘I went as far as I could,’ said Tam. Which was not the same as saying she went as far as she *should*. Her head was so flat from banging on the glass ceiling, she could rest a full dinner plate on it.

‘Well, that’s not quite true, is it?’ replied Jack. ‘You did get to sit in the MD’s chair.’

Tam permitted herself a wry smile.

‘I’m under no illusions about why I was allowed to do that.’

‘What do you mean?’

‘The board needed a mug, a stooge,’ she replied, without thinking too much about what she was saying, because her focus was more on keeping breathing than on the words coming out of her mouth. What did it matter anyway now? She had nothing to lose by being candid. ‘Everyone knew that the first thing the Messiah would do when he landed would be to get rid of the interim, that’s why only I stepped up to the plate.’ *The mug*. Business was ruthless and that’s why no one else had put themselves forward for the job, though none of them were as dedicated and knowledgeable as she was anyway. But she had been willing to take the risk. And she had been a fool, because it hadn’t paid off.

She could see Jack smiling, even in the semi-dark.

‘The Messiah? Is that who I am?’

Maybe she shouldn’t have said that, with hindsight. But she had, so there was nothing to do but own it.

‘Well, you are, aren’t you?’

According to his page on Wiki, he was thirty-six, had an Italian father and Yorkshire mother. He had once been married to a concert violinist, but no children, and he boasted an amazing cache of business achievements. Tam would have allowed herself to be impressed by his credentials had he not nicked her job, but she just couldn’t bring herself to gift him any brownie points. No one would have taken more care of getting YorkMart back to where it should have been in the marketplace than her, not even him with all his past proven successes.

His amused, smiling face was annoying her.

‘I was making great inroads before I was ousted, you know.’

Jack folded his arms, kinked his head. ‘Tell me.’

Okay, she would then.

‘Turnover rose, customers were being lured back from those bargain-famous supermarkets whose names we shall not mention. I brought in the internal incentive scheme for the workforce, asking those doing the actual jobs how they might be improved in stores, on the machines and computers and systems they operate day in day out, and we gained some truly amazing insight very quickly. There were things I wanted to implement but they would have taken longer to show their effect, of course, but I once got a standing ovation from Sir Roland in a board meeting.’

Sir Roland was the chairman, whose father had built up YorkMart from a market stall, and he was always notoriously difficult to impress (unless you were one of his golf cronies). At night in bed, she’d visualised being told by the board that they were taking her on permanently as MD. She would make it happen by brain power.

‘You have no idea how big the mess to sort out was when Martin Middlewood left, and I *was* sorting it.’ Ha – *a mess* was like saying a tsunami was a bit damp. ‘But, let’s be honest about it, the board wanted a man in charge. And you just happen to be a . . . a genius as well as a man. But I was doing a great job.’

She dropped a big breath, spent. She felt a stone lighter for saying all that had been weighing down her heart for a full month.

Jack nodded slowly, digesting her words before speaking. 'I think you're right. Not about me being a genius or a *Messiah*, but about the board preferring a male in charge. Though it didn't work out too well with Middlewood, did it? You would have thought they'd have learned a lesson there. I've read all about what a disaster he was. And I've seen what you did to undo the damage. You accomplished a hell of a lot in those weeks as MD.'

Was he patronising her? She couldn't tell.

'You must have been gutted to hear your position wasn't going to be permanent,' he went on.

Gutted didn't even touch it, thought Tam. She'd been summoned to the board for a formal meeting after two months, long enough to start proving herself, and she *knew* in her heart that they were going to offer her the job without looking elsewhere. In the bath the previous night, she had practised her acceptance speech, which wouldn't have been out of place orated in the Roman Senate. On that day she'd worn this same black suit, again paired with the beautiful Louboutins she had on now.

Tam had strutted in her posh shoes into the boardroom, where the 'fusties', as she secretly called them, were assembled. This was *her* moment.

But . . . Sir Roland thanked her for being such a credible stand-in and now the feted Jack Cesaroni was going to take the wheel and he hoped that she would give her most splendid support to him because she wouldn't be drafted back to Ops; her old department would be absorbed into another, but she was to act as Jack's sidekick and she knew what that meant. He would parasite all he needed to know from her, then she would be toast because there would be no place for her to go.

How exciting for them all that they had persuaded him to join them.

How flaming exciting indeed.

Tam had stuck her fingernail in her hand to quell the rise of emotion in her throat. All her great plans for the company up in smoke.

Gutted, Jack had said she must have been. He didn't have a clue how gutted it was possible to be.

Chapter 3

APRIL – TWO WEEKS BEFORE THE LIFT

Tam had been dreading telling her family that she was no longer MD in an acting capacity or otherwise. She knew both her brother and sister would delight in the upstart being put back in her place.

Sometimes, Tamantha wondered if she had been swapped at birth with a child from different parents who weren't all about appearances and who didn't have stones for hearts. Something she remembered from very early on in her school life, so it must have been significant enough to linger in her brain, was her father reading aloud her school report and harrumphing at what her teacher had written: *Tamantha is a very kind and pleasant girl*. She'd beamed at that and her father had destroyed her pride with that single scornful sound. As she got older, Tam realised he'd have been more impressed if her teacher had written: *Tamantha has absolutely no conscience and would step on anyone to get to the top*. The word 'kind' never appeared on any of her siblings' school reports. She'd read them and they were full of 'intelligent, driven, will-go-far's, but there was nothing about either of them being nice. Because they weren't.

Tam concluded she must be a throwback like one of her aunts, who was a bit dotty but really sweet. Her father, mother and siblings were all slim and willowy with pale-blue eyes and straight fair hair whereas she had wild dark hair and was much shorter in stature (or 'squat', as her brother liked to say). Her features were softer, her eyes big and hazel, her lips fuller. She couldn't have been more different to the family mould. And she had admitted something to only one person in her life – not Natasha or Harris but Anna, a friend she'd had at uni – that she may have been designed to love her relatives on some intrinsic level, but she didn't like them very much at all.

The plan had been to leak the news about her job demotion to her parents first, but she hadn't had the chance. What she didn't want to happen was what, in the end, did happen.

‘Do we have a dress yet?’ asked Davina Bullivant, spearing some guinea fowl on to her fork while staring hard at Tam with her beady little bird eyes. ‘Isn’t it a little ridiculous that you haven’t got one yet, with the wedding in six weeks?’

‘I’m on the case now,’ Natasha answered in Tam’s stead. ‘I’ll find the one we want.’

Tam noted the ‘we’. Even from Natasha. This wedding had been hijacked from the off by her mother and mother-in-law-to-be. The menu, the venue, the choice of bridesmaids, the printed order of service, flowers, hymns – every element of it. Tam was only surprised they hadn’t dictated in what positions she and Harris would have sex on their wedding night. It had been easier to just relent rather than fight them. It would be exquisite, of course, of that she had no doubt, but the one thing Tam had insisted on was choosing her own dress. She must have tried on at least a hundred, but not one of them had made her think, *this is the one*. She had gone dress shopping alone because she didn’t want to be swayed by anyone’s opinions, and as fond as she was of Natasha, she could be a bit ‘my way or the highway’ on occasion. But with the wedding so close, Tam did think it was maybe time to enlist her help and so they were going shopping together next weekend.

‘Finally, there will be a result,’ said Davina, smiling indulgently at her daughter.

‘Make sure it is a dress that befits a company Managing Director,’ said Thomas, from his place at the head of the table.

Harris turned to Tam and said, not under his breath, ‘Oh, haven’t you told them?’

Tam’s heart sank into her shoes.

Hellen was straight on it. ‘Told us what?’

Harris cringed and mouthed an apology at Tam.

Jame’s face said he’d possibly guessed what was coming.

‘Oh, don’t tell us it’s bad news?’ Though his tone intimated that he hoped it would be.

There was nothing for it but to confess now she had been forced into a corner. Tam took in a breath to strengthen herself and then delivered the news as casually as she could. ‘Sadly, I’m not the MD any more.’

‘Shock,’ said Hellen, dabbing at her lips with her napkin, not even attempting to throttle back on the sarcasm.

‘Ah,’ nodded her father. ‘Did what I imagine happen then?’

Tam didn’t ask what that was, but she could make a stab at it.

‘They managed to woo Jack Cesaroni to the firm,’ she answered calmly, forcing out a bright smile that didn’t reach as far as her eyes.

‘Who on earth is he?’ asked Hellen distractedly.

‘Big cheese. King Stilton. Hatchet man,’ explained her father with a sniff. Of course he knew the name. He’d been an industry chief before he retired, and a hatchet man himself. ‘Someone they bring in when they want to chop out the dead wood.’

Tam’s mother got up from the table and approached her. Tam prepared herself for a hug because she really needed one, but Samantha was merely on a mission to get to the dish of buttered cabbage.

‘How unfortunate,’ Davina supplied, looking sympathetically at Tam as if making the assumption that she and dead wood were somehow connected.

‘Still, I imagine your redundancy package will be quite substantial,’ said Jame, whose main focus in life was always the money.

‘Where will you go, Tam? What will you do?’ piped up Meredith, making a rare contribution to conversation. Halley’s Comet went past more often than Meredith dropped a comment.

‘I’m not going anywhere,’ said Tam, sounding much braver than she felt. ‘I’m to act as Jack’s second-in-command.’

‘I suppose being demoted to an assistant is better than the dole,’ said Jame with more than a touch of glee.

‘Don’t be cruel, Jame,’ admonished Meredith.

‘Oh, shut up, Meredith, she knows I’m only joking,’ said Jame, not liking one bit that his girlfriend had the affront to tell him off, which told in the rough way he nudged her with his elbow.

‘Anyway, I have good news,’ said Davina. ‘I’ve sourced some wonderful personalised serviettes for the wedding.’

‘Whoop-de-doo,’ said Jame, rolling his eyes.

And for the first time in probably ever, Tam found herself in agreement with her brother.

Chapter 4

THE LIFT

The lift made a squeak that was most easily heard by bats and dogs and dropped a short way, though it felt like much more. Tam released a similar squeak of distress as her heart made a bid for freedom from her chest.

‘I see you’ve requested a chunk of holiday in June. Going anywhere nice?’ asked Jack from his corner.

‘What?’ Tam couldn’t concentrate on anything but her imminent death. Any moment the lift would plummet downwards at G-force speed, she was sure of it.

‘A request for three weeks’ holiday?’ said Jack, pulling her attention. ‘Long-haul trip, maybe?’

‘I’m getting married,’ said Tam shakily. If she got out of here alive, of course. It wasn’t looking good. She could visualise the cables holding them between the floors fraying under the strain. If they did manage to hang on, there was also the possibility of them cooking in this metal box because it was getting hot in here. Her suit felt tight. She’d never liked it, but Harris said it was smart and something that ‘befitted her status’. He’d laughed at her wardrobe when they got together, said he’d need to take her clothes shopping. She’d thought that was sweet and caring at the time. But did men really have any concept of how hard it could be to walk in heels? She really wanted to kick off these shoes but she was frightened she’d never get them back on again if she did.

The lift made another judder and Tam squawked. This really wasn’t fun.

‘Ah, I see. Big wedding? Come on, focus on something else. Tell me about your plans,’ encouraged Jack, and Tam realised he was trying to distract her. He must really think of her as a wet lettuce making more noises than a human beatbox.

‘Erm . . . yes,’ she said, trying to pull herself together, limit the damage. ‘Big.’

‘How big?’

‘Well, we’re having it at St Michael’s Church, if you know it. It’s about the size of St Paul’s Cathedral. Lots of guests, don’t know most of them. Lobster and prawn cocktail starter. I don’t even like lobster, I feel sorry for them. Beef main, although my mother-in-law pretends she’s French whenever she says it and pronounces it *buuurrrfff*. And some sort of Eton mess afterwards and that’s only because it’s got the word “Eton” in it, I’m sure. I haven’t had much to do with the plans. I’m excluded from them.’

‘Oh?’ replied Jack to that, sounding puzzled. ‘Are you sure it’s *your* wedding?’

‘My mother and mother-in-law are quite formidable. And seeing as the families insisted on paying for the wedding, they insist on organising everything. I can’t exactly argue with that. Although I want to, because the bridesmaids are all in snot green because it will complement the oceanic shades that they’re both wearing. It’s all about coordination, you see. I didn’t pick the bridesmaids. Well, I did one because she’s my friend, but another is my brother’s girlfriend and she hardly talks and has terrible taste in men, and then there’s Kärèn, my fiancé’s cousin, she spells her name with an umlaut *and* a grave accent, so I think you can guess the sort of pretension I’m dealing with – and her seven-year-old daughter, who I’ve never yet seen without her finger inserted up her nose . . .’

Tam’s voice tailed off while she took a breath. Panic was giving her diarrhoea of the vocal cords. And like diarrhoea, she couldn’t stop the flow.

‘I wanted pink and yellow, like Battenberg colours, but that wouldn’t have done at all. I thought it would be bright and jolly. I love Battenberg.’

‘So do I,’ said Jack.

‘But no, I have to have “olivine” or *oliveeeeeen*, which is how the woman who has made the bridesmaid dresses pronounces it. It’s actually not olivine at all, which is a really pretty colour, it’s bleached bile at best, blanched bogey at worst. Awful.’

Harris’s voice sounded in Tam’s head, telling her to shush. He quite often told her off, for her own good, of course, to stop her making a twerp of herself as she was right now.

‘Oh dear,’ said Jack. Even in this dim light, Tam could see Jack was tapping at his mouth as if to scare away his amusement.

‘I have a sister, but she wouldn’t be seen dead as a bridesmaid. If she isn’t the centre of attention, she’s not playing.’

‘Just the one sister?’ asked Jack.

‘And a brother,’ said Tam. ‘She’s a very successful barrister and he’s a very clever eye surgeon. I come from a family of high achievers so I’m the embarrassing failure.’

‘Oh, I wouldn’t say that,’ said Jack, which was rich from someone who was about to give her the boot, Tam thought.

‘I would,’ Tam replied. ‘I’m not ruthless enough to be—’ She bit off the *like you*. One had to be formed from iron to be properly successful. Her sister didn’t pack away her brutal court personality with her powdered wig when her duties were done and her brother, she bet, would be an obnoxious arse to work for, much the same as their father had been. Most people at that level gloried in their reputations of being hard line and difficult, as if their self-important arrogance made them special. Someone too lofty to even say thank you to a PA who brought them in a coffee. Although, she had to admit, Jack Cesaroni had impeccable manners; she’d allow him a brownie point for that.

The bosses who were in situ when she first joined YorkMart were cast from a different foundry, though, being both efficient and approachable. When they said, ‘My door is always open’, they meant it. Exceptions to the rule rather than the rule, but she’d always thought that’s the way it should be. It would have been the way she’d have had things if she was still in charge.

The lift creaked ominously and Tam’s eyes shuttered down in quiet fear.

‘Are you having a honeymoon?’ asked Jack quickly, dragging Tam’s attention back to him and away from impending doom.

‘Not immediately. I’ll be using the time after the wedding to move in with Harris because we can’t find a house we both agree on, so I’ll have to hole up with him. It’s not ideal, but I wasn’t going to buy somewhere I didn’t like just because I felt under pressure. I’ve been too busy to pack up my things before now, though I think part of me has been using that as an excuse because his place is awful. There’s no room for me in it—’

Shut up, Tamantha. That inner voice again. She took a breath, steadied.

‘Plus he has some banking exams to study for, so we’ll go later. Maybe Australia. He has family out there.’

‘Sounds good,’ said Jack.

She stopped herself from disagreeing, from saying that she really didn’t want to go there and stay with his relatives, especially because when he had mentioned it at one of the Sunday lunches, Davina had said she might travel out with them. It wouldn’t be much of a honeymoon with her in tow, taking command as was her forte.

‘And I presume you have the fairy-tale dress?’

Tam swallowed down a bark of laughter. Therein was a tale. Oh the dress. Where to even begin on answering that one.

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Chapter 5

THE PREVIOUS FRIDAY

Three days before Tam was trapped in the lift with her boss of four weeks, preparing to either plunge to the ground and die or suffocate or bake in the airtight box, Jack Cesaroni had told her to prepare for getting the chop. There had been no other way of interpreting his words.

At precisely five-thirty she had knocked on his door and said politely, ‘Goodnight, have a nice weekend,’ and he had rewarded her by swivelling his head from his iMac and saying, ‘Could you make sure you’re on time on Monday, please. There’s a meeting upstairs at nine sharp with the board and it is essential you are there.’

‘I’m never late,’ she said, hackles raised, a fake stretch of smile counteracting the micro-snap in her voice.

‘Yes, I know. I’m just making sure as I have an announcement to make . . . and it concerns you.’

It sounded ominous. He must have taken her standing there musing as a need for clarification.

‘The mess is bigger than I was led to believe so I’m bringing my own people in, just in case you were wondering,’ he said. ‘Goodnight.’

His *goodnight* sounded like a dismissal. A permanent dismissal? He was preparing her, she knew it. What else could his words mean? Was he implying she was part of the mess? She’d tried to sort it, but it would have taken a lot longer than the few weeks she had in her big chair. Now his chair, of course. This was a basic psychological tactic to upend her, have her fretting all weekend. Yes, he might have been all charm and smiles on the surface, but only a little below the veneer he was just a control freak, devoid of empathy, and didn’t this just prove it? She could see through him as clearly as if he were one of those transparent jellyfish.

They hadn’t really had a lot of interaction so far, other than him asking her for reports and her delivering them. He’d been polite, if not warm, efficiency first. He had pored over every minute detail she had supplied.

She was aware that she was making herself redundant by telling him everything he needed to know, give or take her personal opinions on some people that – on balance – she wasn't sure whether or not to share, but she couldn't stop herself. Not if it was for the good of something she cared about so much.

She'd been surprised by her first impression of him, had expected him to strut in on his inaugural morning with an air of entitlement. He'd made quite the entrance in a stunning midnight-blue suit and blinding white shirt, with members of the board trailing and fawning behind him as if he were Harry Styles, but his manner had been anything but 'film star'. He had smiled, held out his hand to her and said, 'Hi, you must be Tam, I'm Jack Cesaroni.'

She shook his hand and resisted telling him that he sounded like a pizza. She had tried to smile, aware that she was terrible at smiling when she didn't mean it and her expression resembled that of someone with bad wind.

'Welcome aboard,' she said, inwardly wincing at how corporate that sounded. *This is the start of the rot*, she thought, because that's what Martin Middlewood would have said. He was full of all the management bollocks-speak phrases like: 'let's square the circle', 'herd the cats', 'paradigm shift' – using them in all the wrong contexts.

She'd then been forced to accompany Jack-who-sounded-like-a-pizza around the building, because he asked her to and she was now his salaried slave and must comply. He walked through every office introducing himself like the King backstage at the Royal Variety Performance. If Tam had been an efficient stats person, like Olek in Accounts, she would have guessed that he shook over seventy-five per cent of the workforce's hands. Tam liked Olek enormously and had she remained in the top job she would have elevated him to the position he deserved, because Olek had more financial acumen in his little finger than his boss, Richard Idle, also known as 'Idle Dick', had in his whole brain. Idle's rise up the ranks had nothing to do with the fact that he was Sir Roland's best golf buddy. Nothing at all. Obvs.

Tam had made sure she gave Jack a glowing introduction to Olek. And she did the same with Sheila in HR, a fabulous woman who had defused many a bomb situation and done her best for anyone who had quit, or been forced to quit, the increasingly toxic regime. Too few people realised that

without Sheila's input, their 'goodbye package' wouldn't have been quite so generous.

During the last few weeks, Tam just got on with what was expected of her, always aware of the Sword of Damocles perched above her head primed to fall at any given moment. And finally, that Friday night after the brief-but-telling convo with Jack, she realised it was going to fall in the boardroom on Monday just after nine.

So it was no wonder that she really wasn't in the cheeriest mood for wedding-dress shopping with Natasha that weekend. She did her best to appear keen but worry and tension were leaking out of her every pore and no amount of silk, tulle or taffeta was going to fix it.

'Well, I must say you're acting more like a person looking for funereal clothes rather than a wedding dress,' scolded Natasha, as Tam walked out of the changing room dressed like a puffball mushroom.

They had been in Maura's Bridalwear in Meadowhall Mall for almost two hours already. Tam now understood why people shot off to Gretna Green to get married in jeans. She wished she could just relent and pick something that was 'okay', but for a reason she couldn't really comprehend, she was doggedly still holding out to find *the* dress, the one that called to her heart, the one that offset her choices being swallowed up by the decisions of others. It was more than important she claim this one element: the dress. And she would not back down.

'That's the worst yet,' said Natasha, shaking her head.

The mirror was throwing back a reflection of a doll-in-a-crinoline that people in the seventies used to cover up their loo rolls. It would have looked much better on Natasha, who was tall and reed-slim like everyone seemed to be in Tam's immediate intimate circle.

Tam went back into the changing room, ready for dress five hundred. It didn't look anything special hanging up, but the shop assistant had brought it in, urging her to try something a little different from what Natasha had prescribed: ornate, showy, designer. This one was understated, simple, ivory lace with bell sleeves and no uncomfortable boning. She slipped it on, lifted her head to the mirror and gasped.

Her reaction to it was a little strange, emotional even, because the reflection was of a Tam she had been but no longer was: a little-bit-bohemian Tam, who liked embroidered tops with hippy sleeves and bell-bottoms. The Tam in whose skin she felt most comfortable. The Tam that

Harris had fallen in love with but somehow she had evolved away from and she didn't know why. Seeing her reflection, she smiled; she liked being *this* Tam. There had been some rain this morning and the damp had kinked her hair from its now-usual styled poker-straightness. It took years off her, made her look fresher and more like the student who had a best friend called Anna with a similar bonkers wardrobe and mad hair.

This was it. This was *the one*.

Unfortunately, *the* dress would not go with the cathedral-length veil that Davina had insisted on because such a venue called for pomp. Instead, it was crying out for a circlet of flowers and cute pumps on her feet. Wouldn't that be great, because she would be able to enjoy her day without spending most of it in pain and hunting down a chair. Okay, she'd be three inches shorter without heels, but surely people would want her to be comfortable as well as pretty on her big day – and she really did look pretty in that dress. How could she not? It was gorgeous. It was pure fairy-tale.

She walked out of the changing room and saw the shop assistant's face break into a smile. 'You look amaz—'

'Well, *that's* not going to happen,' Natasha said at the same time.

'I love it,' said Tam with breathy reverence.

'You'd make a mockery of the day,' said Natasha over-harshly. 'The boys are in morning suits. My mother has bought a Victoria Beckham dress. The Lord-Lieutenant of South Yorkshire AND the High Sheriff are both coming. You can't wear something that makes you look as if you're a reject from 1960s Woodstock.'

Tam stared deep into the mirror at her reflection. If she had been Cinderella, this is the dress the fairy godmother would have magicked up for her out of a pumpkin or a mouse or whatever it was she enchanted.

'No, no, you can't have it,' said Natasha, with a tone that prickled Tam. 'Take it off. You have no sense of style and I do, trust me. Try the first one on again. That was the best out of them all by far.'

Natasha could be just like her brother sometimes. When they were right, everyone else was wrong and there was no debate, no argument to be had.

Tam's eyes flicked to the shop assistant and she could tell she didn't agree. She was most definitely on Tam's side.

Tam took the dress off and tried on the one Natasha preferred again. It was okay, but it didn't have the X factor even if it would look the business

in the photos. Tam was beyond tired of trying on dresses now and more than deflated. Did it really matter if she wore the one that would pass muster with everyone else except herself? Did it?

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Chapter 6

THE LIFT

The lights in the lift flickered. There was a crack as if something complicated and electrical had blown, and Jack and Tam were plunged into total darkness, just for a few seconds but enough to spike Tam's anxiety level.

'Dear God, I know I haven't been to church in ages but I am getting married in one soon so you are important to me. Like my Aunt Rosemary, who I don't see too much but I think about her all the time because she's not like the rest and I think she must be a throwback, like I am,' said Tam, squeezing her hands together and issuing her prayer, which was more audible than she'd intended, because Jack responded.

'What a coincidence. I have an Aunt Rosemary too. Not a name you hear much of these days, is it?'

'I'm sorry for this irrational fear I have of lifts,' said Tam, flashing her eyes towards him. 'I would appreciate it if you didn't judge my entire personality and work abilities on the events of this hour.' It needed saying.

'I wouldn't,' replied Jack, holding up his hands in mock surrender. 'For the record, I have an irrational fear of balloons. If I'm in the room with them, I find myself tensing up. It's the unpredictability of them popping at any given moment. They freak me out. If that makes you feel any better.'

It didn't really. He was probably making it up anyway in his quest to be seen as down with the plebs.

Tam began to pray again, even if she doubted she was being listened to.

Jack continued his questioning of her. 'So . . . how long have you been together with your partner? Harris, did you say he was called?'

'Four years.'

'How did you meet?'

'Through his sister, Natasha, who I met when I was roped into doing a charity Women in Business thing for *Children in Need*.'

Four years. It felt like a lifetime ago. She'd just split up from someone and her ego was in her boots, her well of smiles dried up. Then she happened to be thrown together with an accounts manager in another firm in a three-legged race, and they were both equally matched in their inability to coordinate. They'd celebrated coming last with a coffee and they got on well, chatted for almost two hours. It had made her feel valued that someone liked her company so much as to want to meet up again. She'd sacrificed her social life on the altar of trying to build up her career, trying to make her parents as proud of her as they were of her gifted siblings, and had virtually no life outside work. So that when she needed a friend, there weren't any around, no one to talk to but her old Siamese cat, Walter. He wasn't that great a conversationalist, but he was somewhere to invest the reserves of love she had, and he helped to make her not feel quite so alone. She hadn't had a true friend in her life since Anna at uni and they'd drifted apart long ago.

'One day, Natasha's brother turned up to give us a lift home from the theatre when our taxi didn't materialise.' She smiled in the dark, remembering her first sighting of him: so incredibly handsome, tall, golden-haired. He'd opened the car door for her and she immediately thought, *This is someone my parents would like*. So far, no one she'd taken along for Sunday lunch had met with their approval.

'I didn't think I'd made that much of an impression on him as he never rang. At least, not until weeks later. My old cat, Walter, had just died – he went to sleep and never woke up. He was a huge chocolate-point Siamese and the previous owners of the house I'd bought just left him behind, can you believe? I loved him so much and I was absolutely heartbroken. I felt as if someone had taken the top layer of my skin off, if I'm honest. And then out of the blue Harris rang me and asked me out to dinner.' She didn't say that she was ripe for a man to breeze into her life offering some much-needed attention, because it sounded pathetic.

'What's he like?' asked Jack.

'A gent, cultured, drop-dead gorgeous,' replied Tam, ignoring the burn of her heels as she leaned back against the metal walls of the lift, aware of just how close Jack Cesaroni was. 'He likes the finer things in life. We go to some wonderful places to eat and he always pays, even though I do offer because I'm not a freeloader. And he's really good at presents. He bought me these shoes, not that you can see how properly fabulous they are in this

light.’ He’d bought her a whole wardrobe of clothes, in fact. Out went her ‘boho nonsense’ and in came the separates he said would suit her better. He wanted her to be a classy woman and she wanted to be that classy woman for him. She wanted him to approve of her. She had spent a lot of time in her life chasing approval, now she thought about it.

‘He always has my best interests at heart,’ Tam went on, though she didn’t go into details. It might sound a bit odd to confess to an outsider that he preferred her wild cloud of hair straightened – *just because it’s natural, that doesn’t mean it doesn’t look a little silly* – or that he figured she was pretty enough without wearing all that make-up. There was nothing wrong with telling her to act her age and be more ladylike, even if that off-the-wall giggly girl inside her didn’t feel quite done with her yet. He didn’t want her to make a fool of herself. What was wrong with that? She wondered if Anna had grown up in the years since she’d last seen her, acquired a sober wardrobe and consigned her Ruby Woo red lipstick to the bin. They’d discovered it together on the MAC counter at Boots one day. It was a fabulous shade and she’d worn it for years, but Harris didn’t like it, he said red lipstick was vulgar – so she stopped.

‘I did notice the shoes. Louboutins,’ Jack said, with a nod to them.

She followed his gaze. ‘I just wish they were as fun to wear as they are to look at, but Harris is tall and I look daft in flats when I’m out with him. He’s very stylish and I’m not naturally, so it’s nice to be with someone who has an eye for . . .’ Her voice trailed off. In her effort to show him off, she seemed to be doing exactly the opposite. ‘He’s high up in finance. He’s very clever,’ she continued, because she was on much safer ground talking about his job. ‘He’s also very encouraging about my ambitions.’

Although. She hadn’t quite been able to shake off the disappointment that he had been less than effusive when she told him that she’d been made MD of YorkMart. She and Anna would have danced around the room like idiots. She missed letting her corsets out, being crazy, being the girl she had caught a glimpse of again in the mirror of the wedding-dress shop only two days previously.

She still thought of Anna and it was usually when she needed a friend most of all, but the sort of friend that would listen to her without judgement, and that wasn’t Natasha.

She had met Anna on their third day at uni. She had been drawn to her light, which was bonkers really because Anna had told her later that she had

been attracted by her vibe and Tam had thought she was joking. Did she even have a vibe? Especially one that this Amazonian-tall, white-blonde, funny, kind, confident queen would have noticed? Anna looked Swedish and she convinced so many that she was, faking the language and sounding like the chef on *The Muppet Show*, even though her only connection with Sweden was her fondness for Ikea's meatballs. Tam laughed more in those three years at uni than in all the eighteen years before that. They were both on the same course and worked as hard as they played. They were going to share a flat and hit the business world with their joint genius when they were armed with their degrees, but instead Anna met Leo, a Spanish maths student, and fell head over heels. As soon as they'd graduated, Anna moved out to Spain and got married. What had once seemed like a rock-solid friendship had crumbled like chalk over the next year or so.

The last that Tam knew, Anna was working as the head of PR for a firm in London; she'd looked her up four years ago, when she was at a low ebb. She'd changed her name back from Silva to Anderson, so presumably her marriage to Leo had ended. Tam hadn't dared to contact her, though; she couldn't bear the thought that Anna might not reply. Best to leave the happy memories intact and accept that Anna had outgrown her and moved on. Tam had thrown herself into her career even more after that, but it never quite filled the empty space where her friend used to be. So was it any wonder that when she met Natasha, she sucked up the connection like a thirsty sponge? And then Harris arrived on the scene and her poor battered heart felt the restorative heat of his interest in her. The best moment, though, came when she invited him for Sunday lunch, and the full sun of her parents' approval lit up the dining room. They loved him. Sometimes, she wondered if they preferred him to her. On paper, their relationship was perfect. Each family an ideal complement to the other, both principal players clever and ambitious, with great jobs. They were staring at a future that would be solvent and comfortable and content.

Okay, so there were a few niggles, which would be ironed out over time, Tam was sure. Little things, though. Harris wasn't a passionate man, but Tam had accepted that. He wasn't one for puppyish excitements, declarations of love or throwing her over his shoulder and carrying her up to bed. That kind of thing happened in films and books, not in real life, Harris had once said when she'd been a bit tiddly and had leapt on him in the car. Real love was sensible, solid and not silly like that. And considering

the relationships she'd had that had been distinctly wilder but had ended so hurtfully, she could only conclude that he might be right. Everything else was good. He didn't cheat on her, he didn't eye up other women when he was with her, he didn't lie to her, use her or ever give her reason to doubt what he said was true, all of which she had experienced with other boyfriends. But sometimes, though she tried to bat the thought away, she did wonder if part of her had fallen for what Harris wasn't, rather than what he was.

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Chapter 7

THE LIFT

The lift dropped again and Tam's hand gripped the long pile of the carpet on the floor in panic. It was ridiculously plush, something that Jack drew attention to.

'Superlative-quality carpet in here, isn't it?'

Tam nearly laughed. 'One of Middlewood's last innovations. Top-notch to impress visitors.'

Jack noted her scoffing tone. He tilted his head at her.

'You don't sound as if you approved.'

'I think any attempt to impress folk with a fancy carpet is going to be negated by them being stuck in it like we are. The whole lift system is well overdue for replacement, but he preferred to plaster over cracks,' she responded, surprised that her breathing was evening out as she talked with Jack.

'Yes, I've noticed, from the expense reports,' said Jack. 'He made some very . . . dubious purchases.'

Jack had pored over every letter and figure she'd supplied to him. She could imagine that he'd taken in whatever detail his eye touched, like a cross between a high-functioning computer and a sponge: budgets, time sheets, personnel files, petty cash, big cash. Everything. No corner unpoked at.

'There's a lot of money that's been wasted in this company over the past five years since he took charge,' explained Tam. 'And not enough spent where it should have been.'

If she was going to go out, then she'd go out with a bang and tell him what she hadn't so far, though if he was as clever as everyone said he was, then he'd have already suspected it.

'Such as?'

'Such as he would have been better spending the company's money on decent pay rises for people who deserved them and not throwing it away on

the . . . *dead wood*.' The yes men whose salaries he pumped up.

'Interesting.' Jack's dark eyebrows were rising. 'And who would you say is the . . . dead wood?'

Should I? Tam mused. Given the chance to air her feelings, to be indiscreet and unprofessional . . . should she reel off the list of those she would have winkled out, given the time? The leeches, the fat cats who drew multiples of the salaries the real workers did.

Oh, go on, said an imp on her shoulder. *What have you got to lose?* There were worse ways to use up the remaining oxygen at their disposal than to help some of the people who didn't have a voice in the company.

Tam cleared her throat.

'Richard Idle, head of Accounts, couldn't count to two with his own hands to assist him unless he had a calculator in one of them, and even then I'm not sure he has the gumption to turn it on. Frances Belk in PR should be on a Roman rowing boat, flogging slaves. If you look at the staff turnover in that department, it should tell you everything. The morale in PR is lower than a snake's belly and it's not fair.' The words flowed like water from a broken tap. If she was going to be leaving, the least she could do is tell Jack the Pizza a few home truths, even if it would blemish her reputation in the process because 'no one likes a telltale', as her mother used to say to Hellen, who was a proper little grass. But, Tam reasoned, it might just help the people who would never have his ear, as she presently did, courtesy of a broken-down lift she was desperately trying to pretend wasn't about to plummet to the ground, and talking helped to keep those fears at bay.

Jack nodded, taking in her words. She could almost see the cogs in his brain whirring round, digesting, analysing. 'You said that there are people who deserved pay rises.'

'I did.'

'Like who?'

'Olek Serafinski, in Accounts. He's an Oxford graduate, you know. Brilliantly efficient and totally overlooked. He runs that department while Richard Idle spends most of his time skiving off batting balls in holes with Sir Roland, or whatever the golf terminology is, so if I'd had more time I would have put him in the driving seat and paid him what he's worth. Jason Clement in Grocery, very insightful and does way more than the job description. Young, but deserves his break or we'll lose him to Freshfield – a few of our good people have gone there in the last couple of years and

who can blame them, but you really don't want to lose any more. Sheila Milner in HR, loyalty written through the middle of her like a stick of rock. If it weren't for her . . .'

Jack listened intently to Tam giving him a rundown of people more invisible to the board than Meredith was at her parents' dinner table, and at the end he said, 'Thank you. Some of those are already on my radar, but not all.'

'Good,' Tam said, with some emphasis. 'There are some really hard-working, unseen people in this firm. And I'm one of them.' She hadn't meant to say that, but it couldn't be put back. 'I might be going to Freshfield myself, actually. I'm sure they'll value my skill set. They tried to poach me last summer, but I didn't go. What an idiot.'

At the time, she didn't think she could leave; she'd been working on a few secret projects behind Martin Middlewood's back to try to undo the damage he was creating. She'd operated like a supermarket version of a ninja, well aware that if she were ever found out, she'd be for the chop. But it was worth it if her efforts could keep the ship steady, or as steady as it was ever going to be with Middlewood's inept bottom in the big seat.

To her absolute shock, Jack replied, 'I know what you did last year.' It sounded like the title of a horror film. 'There were a lot of . . . ends that didn't quite tie up in your department. That bugged me. So I tied them up.'

She gulped. He knew. Despite all her expert fudging. She shouldn't have been surprised – this was Jack Cesaroni and what might have escaped others, he'd never miss.

'You were very clever,' he went on, casually resting his back against the corner of the tiny box they were trapped in, and she couldn't read if he meant that in an appraising way or a critical one.

She felt a blush starting to heat up her cheeks, although it was getting very warm, very quickly in here with their body heat bouncing off the metal surfaces and lush carpeting.

Jack tilted his head at her like a confused spaniel. 'Why would you do it?'

'Because if I hadn't, there might not have been a business left for you to come to. I love this company, and I didn't want it to be broken up and sold as spare parts – and trust me, it would have come to that—'

He interrupted her. 'I don't mean that. I mean, why would you go to Freshfield?'

Her eyebrows crunched down in confusion. *Is he dense?*

‘You already said, you’re bringing in your own people.’

‘Yes, I am.’

She felt like slipping off her stiletto and battering him around the head with it. Then again, that might scupper any decent redundancy package that she knew Sheila would negotiate on her behalf.

The lift creaked, sounding very much as if something was splitting in two. Tam lifted up her right hand and crossed her chest just in case God might be looking down on her, which was likely if he was omniscient.

‘You know, maybe this . . . was meant to happen,’ said Jack, gesturing generally around the suffocating lift. ‘We haven’t really talked together, have we? I’ve had my work cut out since day one trying to get on top of things and I apologise for being . . . distant.’

Tam shrugged. ‘You don’t need to apologise to me. I never expected to be best pals with’ – *the great Jack Cesaroni* – ‘you. It’s work. I get that.’ And it was also a bit late to be having an *entente cordiale* now, just before the big goodbye. She now felt quietly resigned to the end, and it might have something to do with the fact that finding another job paled into insignificance against death by lift-dropping or asphyxiation next to your soon-to-be-ex boss. If she had to go and beg Freshfield for the job she turned down last year she would, although she really didn’t want to go and work for them. She had a funny feeling that Martin Middlewood might end up there. Death would definitely be better than working with him again.

‘With the groundwork done, I’m ready to make the big changes. The important changes. The people changes,’ said Jack.

You don’t have to rub it in, thought Tam, patting at the perspiration pushing out of the pores on her forehead. Her skin felt as if she had a furnace behind it and two big lads were stoking it up with best Yorkshire coal.

‘You were suited to Operations. I do wonder if the board made you into a glorified assistant to me so that your position might become untenable after a short period,’ Jack continued.

‘Of course they did,’ she replied. ‘I was happy in Operations. It makes no sense to merge it with anything else either, let me tell you. I really had a good handle on it.’ There had been no better department to be in in order to meddle, manipulate and manoeuvre pieces around as if she were playing an

expert game of chess. But only ever for the good of the company, not for personal gain the way Martin Middlewood did.

‘You certainly had a handle on *covert* Operations, Miss Remington.’ Jack smiled a smile that sat lopsided on his lips. It was a very attractive smile even in this semi-dark, she would admit that, though she had always remained resolutely impervious to his charm. To his tall, really-dark-hair, really-big-brown-eyes, really-handsome-face charm. His PA, Shirley, whom he’d personally picked from the temp agency, was a fifty-something ex-sergeant major, yet whenever she brought him a cup of coffee over, it shook in the saucer. Her eyes only just fell short of pumping out cartoon hearts when she was in his presence.

He was single, according to the gossip machine, and she wondered why. Obviously a picky sort. Tam, out of curiosity, had looked up a photo of his ex-wife, the violinist. She was stunning, in a kind of haughty, confident way. They’d have had great-looking kids if they’d stayed together.

‘Do you still have your parents around?’ asked Jack, which seemed a bit of a left-field question.

‘My parents?’

‘Having dependent parents can impact considerably on someone’s life, both in and out of work.’

She hadn’t thought someone in such a lofty position as him would be in tune with such a theory, even though when she had been in his position, she was. She knew that Sheila in HR had a mum with dementia and had used up most, if not all, of her holiday days on hospital visits. She’d taken Sheila’s manager to task about that, given him a little lesson in pliancy after seeing Sheila in a state in the staff canteen. Tam had learned from the best in this job, her first-ever managers, that giving some leeway to people reaped harvests.

‘Yes, I know that,’ Tam said, bristling.

‘I know you know,’ Jack said. ‘I heard what you did for the lady in HR.’

Was there any area of YorkMart that he hadn’t stuck his nose into?

‘Thank you, mine are fit and well. Your dad’s Italian, isn’t he? According to Wiki, anyway.’ Did that sound a bit creepy, that she’d been looking him up? She tried to wriggle out of looking weird. ‘I think someone told me you had a . . . a . . . I haven’t seen it myself. Must be nice to have your own . . . Wiki . . . page . . .’

‘Have I? Not anything I’ve set up.’ Jack seemed amused, his dark Italian eyes twinkling in a good-humoured way.

‘Martin Middlewood had one. You could tell he’d written it himself. It was full of his own self-important twattery. He made Bill Gates sound like a tea boy by comparison.’

Jack chuckled. ‘And what does it say on my . . . Wiki page?’

He really hadn’t looked himself up? Wow.

‘Erm . . . I heard . . . it just listed all your successes . . . and that you were married to a concert violinist. No children. From what I recall, I think.’

‘That’s correct. I can only hope your experience of marriage will be better than mine, is all I shall say on that.’ His tone was of someone stating a fact, not of someone bitter about a relationship gone wrong.

‘Doesn’t sound a positive experience,’ Tam said, trying not to sound as nosy as she was.

‘I had parents who were very happily married. I envied them. I wanted that for myself. They married within five months of meeting each other, totally smashing the myth that if one marries in haste, one repents at leisure, except it worked for them because they were right for each other. It didn’t quite work out that way for Rosella and myself. The sad thing is the cracks were already showing before the wedding and I thought that all I had to do was ignore them and they’d heal themselves.’

Tam wanted to know about the cracks. Her brain told her not to pry but her mouth disobeyed and she did ask.

‘Simply put, I married her because I loved her. She married me because of who I might be one day, and therein lies the difference. My mum saw it, and she warned me not to rush into a marriage where someone wanted to change me to fit them. She was right, of course, but I didn’t see it at the time.’

‘Are they still around – your parents?’ she asked.

‘Sadly, no,’ said Jack, his voice soft, sad. ‘They had me quite late, so they weren’t young, but it’s always too soon. I have a brother and a sister, though they’re roughly a decade older than me.’

‘Snap,’ said Tam. ‘Although it feels like there are fifty years between us. We don’t really get on. If they were in this lift, they’d step over us both to get to the last remaining air pocket. I hope yours are nicer.’

She was talking too much, she realised. She didn't want silence because the quiet gave her space to worry about dropping all those floors to the ground – thirteen and a half floors, to be exact. Actually, there was the mezzanine and the basement as well. *Oh hell.*

'My sister is married to a farmer and has six children and a load of rescued donkeys. I can't remember the last time I saw her without wellies on. And my brother, he's a vet. An absolute soft touch. Probably the poorest vet in the country because of his big heart.'

'They sound a nice bunch.'

Jack smiled fondly and his smile reached all the way up to his eyes and made them crinkle at the corners. Good-looking psychopath – like Dexter Morgan.

They sat for a few moments in silence, although Tam didn't know how he couldn't hear her heart thudding in her chest loud as the drums at a Def Leppard concert. There was a whole cocktail of emotions racing around inside her: anger, fear and frustration, all mixed in with adrenaline, which made for a lethal combo. But mainly sadness. She might have been a drip with no confidence outside of work, being buffeted by the winds of others, but here in YorkMart she was on top of her game, her backbone iron, her expertise on point, and it was all about to be taken away from her.

'Will you do me a favour, when I'm gone? Will you make sure that people are looked after in this firm, Jack?' Tam asked him, trying hard to hide the emotion in her words. 'I don't know why Martin Middlewood tried to alter something that was perfect as it was and ended up nearly destroying it, but please restore it. Make it great again. And don't overlook women for the top positions. There would have been more of them if I'd had my way.'

'I will, that's the plan,' said Jack.

'Thank you, I—'

'You all right in there?' A voice from somewhere above interrupted her, accompanied by a clanging sound as if something were being hit with a hammer.

'Just about,' returned Jack.

'We'll have you out of there in no time now. Hang fire.'

Tam's breath of relief was long and drawn out.

'Now that the cavalry has arrived . . .' Jack turned to her. 'And before we go into the boardroom . . .' He paused. 'Do you mind if I tell you what I think about you?'

Well, judging by the way this conversation was going, he might well say she was a blabbermouth, a wuss, a—

‘I think you’re exceptional,’ he said, slicing off her internal dialogue.

The word hung in the air with a long echoey tail.

‘Any company worth their salt would be glad to have you. I have no idea why they didn’t keep you in the top seat. Maybe you should have been more vocal about what you’ve done for YorkMart rather than operate under the cover of darkness. I’m pretty sure anyone else who did all you did would have claimed their glory.’

Tam’s jaw dropped so far open, she was in danger of looking like one of those big mouth things in fairs that people aim footballs at. Jack Cesaroni laughed – at her but not *at* her. Enough people had laughed at Tam over the years for her to differentiate. Most of them blood relatives.

She pulled herself together. ‘I presume you’ll write that on my reference then,’ she said tightly.

‘For Freshfield? Absolutely,’ said Jack Cesaroni, keeping that annoying smile fixed on his MD sadistic face.

Chapter 8

THE LIFT

The lights flashed on and off and then stayed on, with an overbright intensity that caused their eyelids to shutter down against it. The lift juddered up and down as if someone were shaking it and then it slowly and smoothly began to rise. Jack got to his feet and held out his hand to assist Tam up from the floor. She was going to ignore the gesture, but this suit was not conducive to a wide range of movement. He pulled her up easily and just as she got to her feet, the lift bounced and she found herself thrown into his chest. His right hand was still holding her left, his left had come around her to steady her, and to an outsider, it might appear as if they were about to dance.

‘You all right there, Tam?’ asked Jack. Close up and personal, she could smell his cologne, and though she couldn’t put a name to it, it made the receptors in her brain sigh.

‘If I let you go, you won’t fall to the ground, will you?’

Tam wasn’t so sure about that. He was holding her both firmly and carefully and she really couldn’t remember the last time she had been held in someone’s arms like that. Not even Harris’s.

Sex had never been a driving force in their relationship, even if she would have quite liked it to be. It usually happened, like an established habit, when she stayed over at his flat, and that was just once a week, on Saturday nights. Harris presently resided in a minimalist flat whereas Tam lived in a small mews house in a select part of town, which she would be really sorry to let go of. She’d bought it eight years ago, a place for a budding future executive, except her personality had spilled over the walls in the form of bright bold paint. Harris said it gave him a migraine to be in, he couldn’t do with all her cheerful clutter and the tasteless colour scheme and she’d never sell it as it was, so over the last couple of years she’d redecorated throughout with sensible neutrals and with it killed much of that essence that spoke of home. Still, Harris preferred they stay at his more

stylish, spacious gaff, so every weekend she went over there. They didn't really do that much together through the week as they were both too busy working, and Harris had a lot of studying to do around his banking exams, but they'd have a nice dinner on Saturday nights, then maybe some sex when they went to bed. He had learned which of her buttons to press and pressed the same buttons every time. She couldn't have it all. But as Jack was holding her to him, her body was having traitorous reactions that it should only have for her fiancé, and it perturbed her.

'Thank you, I'm fine,' said Tam, stepping away from him, though her whole being still registered the ghost of his hold and she really didn't know why. Residue of panic, she reasoned, her senses confused. She should get a grip. She'd need all the dignity she could muster for what was about to come to her in the boardroom.

Yesterday, she'd tried not to be upset about today, but she had ended up overflowing to Harris as he drove her from her parents' house after lunch. He'd comforted her, of course, said that maybe it was a good thing. Maybe she was ripe for a change. Something a little less intensive, less . . . demanding. Maybe they realised she was out of her depth. And she hadn't said so, but she'd been tempted to ask if she should just give up working altogether and have lots of sets of twins like his mother obviously wanted. If she had, he might have said that was the sort of immature talk that only proved she wasn't fit to be at the helm of a leading supermarket, and he would have been right. So she'd stamped down hard on the rising tears and cried into her pillow later instead. He was wrong; she wasn't out of her depth, she had been swimming around like Michael Phelps, an expert, breathing those depths in as if her lungs were made for them.

The lift cleared floor fifteen. In mere minutes now she'd have to sit there wearing her best wind-smile while she was given a load of guff about how valuable she had been to the company and that they all wished her well. Limp handshakes, limp words with really the same amount of softness behind them as the stiff leather of her shoes. How could she be expected to sit through that? As the lift rose, so did a spiral of annoyance within her, making its exit in Jack 'Pizza' Cesaroni's direction.

Seventeen. They had finally landed and Tam felt sick.

'Do you really need me to be at this meeting? Do I really need to be witness to my own execution in front of that sanctimonious bunch of old farts?'

From the look on his face, she knew she'd shocked him. Good. Maybe it might be enlightening for him to see that people were not pawns to be knocked off the chess table as inconsequential pieces. They all had the potential to be queens.

'What on earth are you talking about?' he asked, as the lift doors began to slide open, slowly, like newborn kittens' eyes opening for the first time.

'I really would prefer to be spared the ignominy of being labelled' – *What's that patronising word he used? Ah yes, that's right – “exceptional”.* So exceptional, in fact, that I'm to be thrown on the rubbish—'

Jack raised his hands and attempted to press her words back at her. 'Miss Remington, I have absolutely no intention of throwing you on a rubbish heap or letting you go to Freshfield or elsewhere. I'd be a fool if I ever considered you not a part of the plans for YorkMart going forward. I want more people like you, not less. What on earth made you think otherwise?'

'But . . . I . . . you . . . said . . . it . . . ' Tam's mouth opened and closed like a bewildered koi carp's.

'I think you may approve of some of my changes. We are absolutely on the same page. Now, if you wouldn't mind . . . '

The doors had fully opened now, and he held out his hand to gesture she leave the lift first.

She was so gobsmacked, the pain in her crushed feet as she stepped out didn't even register above the shock.

PART 2

AFTER THE LIFT

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Chapter 9

If the *fusties* thought they had set on an obedient, if formidable, Labrador who would kowtow to their will, they got a rude awakening in that morning meeting. It made for sobering listening when Jack Cesaroni, complete with PowerPoint illustrations, gave a forensically detailed presentation on the damage they had allowed certain personnel in the company to cause. Was it their mission statement to promote those who hadn't a clue what they were doing just because they had a golf handicap in line with Sir Roland's? Or were 'Teflon' because of secret intimate relations? Tam had heard the rumours about someone on the board's extra-marital fling with Frances Belk in PR and from the way he shifted in his seat when Jack's eyes fell on him, it was clearly confirmed. She was impressed to see that Jack did not duck away from his own mission statement: that people in his companies who were promoted to run departments should run them adequately. And they certainly shouldn't be throwing staff to the lions in order to bury any of their own mistakes. Tam wished she'd brought some popcorn to enhance her enjoyment as she took in each board member's shocked expression. Jack Cesaroni had been brought in to chop out the dead wood, except the dead wood he'd identified took up much more of their forest than the board wanted to believe.

Richard Idle had to go. Frances Belk also. He had an immediate replacement lined up for her. Idle would be no loss seeing as the department was already being run by Olek Serafinski and so he would be given the invitation to formally take over. It wasn't a request.

The board members looked to each other like nervous meerkats but no one said a word. Tam was riveted.

'And, I am going to undo the ridiculous and totally nonsensical decision to merge Ops with Logistics. They should stay as two separate departments and Miss Remington here will return to her previous position as head of the former. She will have elevated duties, working more closely with me, and be paid in line with her increased responsibilities.'

Tam was actually quite glad she didn't have any popcorn at this point because she might have choked on it, coughing with shock.

Jack turned to her, his large dark-brown eyes taking her in. His lashes were sooo long, she noticed.

‘I would like you to hear it from me how much Miss Remington achieved in her albeit brief stint as your MD and I can assure you that your business would have been in very safe hands had she remained as such,’ he went on. All eyes drifted to Tam and she felt her cheeks begin to respond as if eleven hot-air guns were trained on her face. It could have been a twitch in Jack’s eye but it looked like a wink. He didn’t stop there, though. He listed everything she had done to improve staff morale in the last few years, the measures she had taken – unheralded and unnoticed by them – to combat all the one-man wrecking ball Martin Middlewood had inflicted upon the company. His tribute to her was excruciating in its intensity. She was thrown into blessed relief when he switched tack, tearing into the board for allowing themselves to be blinkered, resting on false laurels, trusting people without question when it was their job to be on the ball and look after their shareholders’ interests. At the end of his tirade, the eleven men looked like withered little boys who had just been eviscerated by a headmaster for smoking.

Spent now, Jack turned off the PowerPoint and said, ‘Your thoughts, gentlemen.’ As the fog of shock cleared, the nods of assent began, the twitters of conversation between neighbours. Approval filling the room like a new version of oxygen.

‘That all sounds very . . . impressive, Mr Cesaroni,’ said Sir Roland.

‘And exciting,’ said someone at the end. ‘Very exciting.’

They had been right to invest in such a man, she could feel it emanating from them all. It was quite something to witness Jack Cesaroni in full force and suddenly, as if she’d needed any further proof, Tam knew this was why he commanded the big bucks.

‘Are you okay taking the lift down?’ Jack asked Tam, after they left the boardroom.

‘Erm, yes,’ she supposed. The middle lift they had come up in was marked ‘Out of Service’ now and she figured the likelihood of two failing on the same day would have negligible odds. She could have kicked off her shoes and taken the stairs, of course, something she thought of just as the

lift doors were closing on her. In truth, she wasn't out of the shock bubble of what had just happened – all of it, the whole morning's events from start to finish. No doubt all the lifts would be undergoing a serious review in the next few days, because Jack Cesaroni was a doer. And Tam had enormous admiration for doers. In the initial glory days of YorkMart, everybody in authority was like that. When had it all begun to change? One minute all was great, then the goalposts had started moving subtly, unnoticed, giving a false reading of normality. Thank goodness they'd caught things before they were too late.

Tam stood watching the floor numbers counting down, one word bouncing around in her head like a fly trying to find an escape door.

Exceptional.

Jack Cesaroni had made her feel exactly that in the boardroom. Like someone of value.

'Do you have plans for lunch?' he asked, as they approached floor six. 'There's someone I'd like you to meet.'

'Erm, no, I don't have any plans. Who do you want me to meet?'

'The new head of PR. I'd like you to tell me what you think of them. I've booked a table for three at twelve. Presumptuous of me, I know. Carlo's, around the corner. I've heard it's quite good.'

'It's better than that,' said Tam. 'We are very lucky to have such a place nearby. Lots of business lunch hours are spent there.'

It was a particular favourite of Richard Idle's, who took four-hour pleasure lunches there on the pretext of business. Tam swallowed a smile; she could just imagine the reaction in his department when they found out he was for the chop. They'd have a full-on party and she'd sanction the budget for it. He was one of a few who presumed they were protected by their associations with board members. It was going to come as a shock to them to realise they were not titanium. YorkMart would be all the richer for being poorer of them.

Tam nipped to the loo, refreshed her nude lipstick and spritzed herself with perfume, a heavy, spicy one that Harris had bought for her to replace the signature scent she'd worn for years, which made him cough, he said. It was too sweet and cloying, the perfume of a girl, and she was a woman, if she hadn't noticed. It was no big deal, just a perfume. She'd got used to it now.

Jack was waiting for her by the door down in the atrium. He'd put on his jacket; he had a great line in suits. She wondered if he had them specially made because he had really broad shoulders that tapered to a slim waist like Superman, strong, toned arms that filled his sleeves, and long legs. She didn't think he'd find that shape on a peg.

They talked as they walked. Jack said as they rounded the corner, 'Between you and me, I think that Sheila is overdue a promotion to head of HR. Think she can do the job, Tam?'

Tam looked up at him in surprise. 'In her sleep,' she said with emphasis. Was this really the man who'd been her boss all these weeks? The man who emerged from the lift seemed different to the one who had entered it.

Thank goodness it wasn't a long walk to Carlo's because her feet were killing her. But then Mr Louboutin was credited with saying that comfort was not his priority, his shoes were meant to turn heads. She wished he'd reconsider. The waiter led them over to a booth where Jack's guest was already present and waiting.

Tam's eyes blinked in disbelief. A tall blonde woman had risen to greet them, her expectant smile segueing into shock as her eyes met Tam's.

'Oh my God. Tam!' she exclaimed, her Lancastrian accent unmistakable, unchanged.

Never in a million years would Tam have expected the prospective new head of PR to be her old uni pal, Anna Anderson.

Chapter 10

Jack looked from the tall blonde woman on his left to the shorter brunette on his right and back again.

‘Do you two know each other?’

‘Do we?’ said Anna, a grin taking over all her features. Tam’s face mirrored hers and she found herself opening her arms and they embraced in a long, tight hug. Anna’s lovely perfume filled Tam’s nose and took her back ten years to the joyous days of university. A million images and sound bites and feelings flooded her memory, rushing at her like the best sort of assault.

‘We were best pals at uni,’ said Anna, when they eventually drew apart, that grin Tam had missed just getting wider.

Jack held the chair out for Tam and she sat cautiously, checking the chair was in position because she’d never quite trusted someone not to whip it away as a ruse, a ‘trick’ of her brother’s. He had a puerile sense of humour and she hoped he didn’t do things like that with his patients, stabbing them in their irises for a laugh. He’d done the chair thing to Meredith at a family event. Poor Meredith, she hadn’t said a word, but she’d kept rubbing her back surreptitiously throughout the meal. And the embarrassment must have hurt as much, if not more.

Anna’s hand closed over Tam’s. ‘I can’t tell you how good it is to see you.’ She’d lost nothing of her broad burr despite the years in Spain and then the Netherlands, then London. Not that Tam had been checking . . .

‘You two can catch up when I’ve gone,’ said Jack. ‘I’m sure you have a lot of that to do.’

‘I’d love to,’ said Anna, her eyes trained hopefully on Tam.

‘How . . . how do you two know each other?’ asked Tam, looking between Anna and Jack.

Anna filled her in. ‘A firm I worked for was in a bit of a mess and Jack was brought in to sort it out.’

‘It was one of my biggest challenges,’ nodded Jack. ‘Thank goodness for Anna being there. I was always determined to try and poach her when the opportunity arose.’ He prodded at the menu. ‘Choose. The sooner I eat, the sooner I’m gone and I can leave you to your reunion.’

Her mind reeling, Tam forced herself to concentrate. She was supposed to be having dinner with Harris tonight, looking at houses on Rightmove, so she went for a light bite ravioli and a small accompanying wine. The curator of the wine list at Carlo's was too gifted to resist, she'd never had a bad one yet. Not that she knew much about them. She certainly didn't do the dipping-her-nose-into-the-glass thing and swilling the contents around like Harris did in restaurants. She hated when he decided he didn't like it after all and would ask for a fresh bottle. Despite being a self-styled gent, he could be terribly pompous with serving staff, which made her cringe. She couldn't prove it, but she suspected some waiters must have spat in his soup.

'Tam thought I was getting rid of her,' said Jack as the wine was being poured. He thanked the waiter, Tam noticed.

'Well, you didn't exactly say you weren't,' she said in her own defence, still struggling to accept that she was once again face to face with Anna Anderson.

'I'd just told you that you were exceptional – I thought that might have been a clue.' He smiled and she thought that she must have seen him smile more today than she had done in all the weeks before. He looked so different when he smiled, younger, less like a man who had his own starchy Wiki page full of his fabulous corporate achievements and a brief history of his ex-wife who was nifty on a violin.

'In my old friend's defence, if you had been about to get rid of her, you might well have used the: "You are a woman of many talents, an *exceptional* asset to any company" build-up before you added the "unfortunately, not this one". Terribly manipulative tactic to make yourself look better while delivering a fatal blow that some lesser corporate dickheads of industry might have used. Not you, of course, Jack. I know you're well above such moves.'

It's so good to hear her dulcet, earthy tones, thought Tam. And it was stupidly wonderful to hear herself referenced as 'my old friend'. It made Tam glow from the inside out.

Jack had cannelloni and mopped up the rich tomato sauce with thick chunks of Italian bread. She hadn't got him down as such a hearty eater, and the amount of Parmesan he had applied was on a par with what she'd put on every Italian dish if she could without risking disapproval. No sooner had

Jack swallowed his last mouthful than he checked his watch, stood, and lifted his jacket from the back of his chair.

‘I’ve got a meeting,’ he said. ‘Anna, clear the bill for me and I’ll . . .’

‘Yeah, I’ve got it,’ she replied. Their relationship was easy, familiar. Tam got the feeling they were definitely more than old colleagues.

‘Tam, don’t rush back. It’s been quite the day, so enjoy your lunch. Anna, I’ll phone you later.’ Anna stuck up her thumb by way of an answer.

‘He’s quite something, isn’t he?’ Anna said admiringly when he had left the building.

And Tam replied, ‘If I’m honest, I don’t know him that well. Today is the first time we’ve really spoken.’ And she’d spoken quite a lot today too, which was a problem as she was becoming increasingly uncomfortable about how much she’d disclosed in the lift – stupid trivia, irrelevant detail. She had told him things she hadn’t told anyone else. Mainly because there wasn’t really anyone else to tell.

‘Maybe it was a good thing that you ended up being trapped in the lift with him then. It gave you both the chance to get to know each other. He’s great fun out of his suit.’

Oh they were definitely *close*, Tam decided.

Anna lifted her glass and sipped, wearing a look of someone turning things over in her head. She placed the glass back on the table slowly, pushing it into dead centre of the coaster, building up to something.

‘I owe you a massive apology,’ she said at last.

Tam raised her eyebrows.

‘Do you? What for?’

‘For being the worst friend ever. For committing the cardinal anti-sister sin of dumping a pal for a man.’

Tam gave a little snort of derision. ‘If you mean Leo, that was a long time ago and you were smitten. I’d have done the same to you.’

‘No, you wouldn’t have, Tam.’ Anna shook her head in protest. ‘Anyway, it didn’t work out so I was left with nothing. *C’est la vie*.’ And she shrugged.

‘How’s your mum?’ asked Tam, not quite sure what to say.

‘The same. I don’t see her all that much,’ said Anna. She’d had a difficult relationship with her mother, who had always prioritised her brief and dysfunctional relationships over her daughter. ‘How’s your mum and dad?’

Tam tried not to cringe, remembering that she'd brought Anna to the house to stay for a couple of days and her parents' cold politeness had made it quite obvious that they didn't really approve of this person with her pronounced accent. Anna hadn't said as much, but Tam knew she had seen them for the snobs they were.

'The same,' replied Tam.

'Blood isn't really a guarantee of anything, is it, Tam? I've learned to pick my real family from my friends. I have collected some great mates over the years from various places, but none were ever quite as close as you and . . . I missed you.' She smiled; it sat on her lips heavy and sad. 'I wanted to get in touch with you so many times, but I thought you'd tell me to do one, as you had every right to. Especially because I had the strongest urges to find you when things were going wrong in my life.'

'Oh, I wish you had got in touch. I felt the same. Then I worried we'd have changed too much, lost what we had.' Tam grinned. 'For the record. It's just as if the last time I saw you was yesterday.'

Anna reached for Tam's hand and squeezed and felt the stone of her ring digging into her palm. 'You're engaged,' she exclaimed excitedly.

'Yes, and I'm getting married next month.'

Anna leaned in, her sheet of white-blond hair swinging over her shoulder in her enthusiasm. 'Wow. Give me all the details.'

'I had to kiss a lot of frogs before I found the prince.'

Anna laughed. 'I'm still at the kissing-the-frog stage.'

Tam found herself laughing too and it really did feel like old times. 'Oh, where to start . . . he's called Harris Bullivant. He works in banking. We've been together four years. He's thirty-five. Our families really get on too.'

'So you'll have all your wedding plans sorted by now then. How exciting!'

'More or less,' Tam said, before rushing on, 'but there is one thing I'm unsure of. I don't suppose you're free at the weekend, are you? I could do with your advice.'

Tam had a spring in her step for the rest of the day. She bounced over to Harris's apartment that evening eager to tell him how today had gone,

because it really had been a smorgasbord. She didn't like Harris's place; it was all about the style and not about the comfort and it always felt cold, however much the central heating was tweaked up. Tam really wasn't looking forward to moving in here permanently after the wedding as it was very much Harris's place with not much room for the things she wanted to bring with her, but it would have been weird them living apart as husband and wife. It would be better when they could find somewhere together, though blending their tastes was going to be a challenge. She knew she would have to cut back on her love of the kitsch and kooky and try to acquire his minimalist taste, and he would have to break up his clinical colour schemes with some pastels at least.

When he opened the door, she breezed in, reaching up to give him a smacker on his lips, joy bubbling out of her.

'You'll never guess what,' she said, but giving him no time to guess what. 'I've been promoted. I've got my old position back and then some more. And—'

'Tamantha, will you slow down,' Harris protested. 'Take a breath.'

'I'm excited.'

He arched a brow. 'So I see.'

'I've brought some champagne.' She strode into the kitchen. 'Shall I open it now?'

'I'm not in the mood for drinking anything,' he said grumpily. 'I've had a tough day.'

'Oh, okay,' said Tam, feeling her firework of excitement begin to fizzle out and drop back to earth. She had so wanted to tell him about the lift and the fusties in the boardroom getting obliterated and lunch and Anna, but she didn't. She knew she could be annoyingly fizzy and over-talkative – hadn't that been proved today in the lift?

Instead, they looked at some houses on the internet then ate together and she resisted thinking that if the situation had been reversed, she would have swallowed down her rubbish day and let him talk ad infinitum about his lovely news and rejoiced with him.

After they'd cleared dinner away, Harris didn't try to persuade her to stay over and she didn't ask. He was tired and she was wired, it wouldn't have been a great mix. Instead, she went home and lay in bed, replaying her day. The most perfect day she'd had in a while. But even more than the part about reuniting with Anna, she thought about what had happened in the lift.

How Jack Cesaroni was nothing like she'd imagined really. And most of all, Jack's words – *Do you mind if I tell you what I think about you? . . . I think you're exceptional* – were playing on a loop in her head as she fell asleep encased in the scent of his cologne.

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Chapter 11

THE FOLLOWING SATURDAY

Anna was renting an apartment at the other side of Meadowhall so they arranged to meet at the shopping mall on the following Saturday at eleven, giving Tam the perfect excuse to get out of having coffee with Natasha and her Pilates pals. She would never tell Natasha but, as much as Tam liked the classes, she didn't like that group of women very much. One of them bragged more than Jame about money, one had a disturbing habit of raking her eyes over Tam with CT-scan intensity, and the other was loudly opinionated about everything from worldwide politics to what constituted a Spanish omelette. Natasha chameleoned into the people she mixed with, Tam had noticed over the years. When she was with the 'Witches of Eastwick', as Tam thought of them, her personality changed in line with theirs. She participated in the annoying one-upmanship, and even her accent tweaked itself up. At Sunday lunch, she became a younger version of Davina, and Tam had learned that there were a lot of subjects she should avoid talking about with her because, like her brother, there was no debate to be had in things she felt strongly about.

Tam had been thinking a lot about reuniting with Anna that week; how they'd been texting almost non-stop since their lunch. It cast her friendship with Natasha in a new light. She felt a little guilty, as Tam had never looked forward to meeting up with Natasha the way she was looking forward to spending time with Anna again. But she shook it away; maybe it was just the novelty of Anna being back in her life. Much like relationships, things always did ebb and flow, didn't they?

In Maura's Bridalwear, Tam tried on the dress that Natasha had insisted she buy. She emerged from the dressing room, watching Anna's expectant smile segue into something akin to pain.

'Do you want me to be honest?' Anna asked hesitantly.

The old Anna had never been very good at *not* being honest, as Tam remembered.

‘It’s . . .’ Anna seemed to struggle to find the correct word. Her head moved from side to side as if she were tossing various options around, but the unsaid said more than enough.

‘It is, isn’t it?’ agreed Tam. ‘Now let me show you another one.’

‘Yes, please do, and spare my eyes,’ Anna called out as Tam returned to the dressing room.

A few minutes later, Tam came out wearing the lovely boho dress she’d called ahead about and asked the assistant to put aside.

‘Now, that is you to a tee,’ exclaimed Anna. She opened her mouth to say more but closed it again. It wasn’t like her to hold back.

‘I love this dress so much,’ prompted Tam.

Anna, still seeming to tread carefully in their newly reignited friendship, asked, ‘And so the problem is . . .?’

The shop assistant nodded with approval. ‘It really does look much nicer than the other one. I thought that the last time you came, but your friend was so . . . convinced—’

‘What friend?’ asked Anna, whirling around in disbelief. ‘You can’t possibly have a proper friend who thinks the best look on your wedding day is that of a miniature Abominable Snowman.’

Tam snorted.

‘Surely,’ Anna went on, ‘the question is . . . what dress do *you* want to wear at *your* wedding?’

‘This one,’ breathed Tam, and she sighed heavily as she took in her reflection in the long mirror. It really looked as lovely as she remembered. It *was* her wedding and the dress part of it was the most important of all for her – as well as the groom, of course. She could put up with the prawn and lobster and the *buuurrrfff* main course, but she wanted to wear a dress that made her feel like she was feeling now. Even if it was too understated to fit with all the arranged grand components of the day.

Anna helped her pick out some shoes, ivory lace pumps. In those shoes, she could stand up all day and dance all night. No cathedral-length veil either, but a circlet of silk flowers – pink-and-yellow Battenberg colours, with not a hint of *oliveeeeeen*.

They went for lunch in the busy shopping mall and when they were relaxing with a mocktail, Anna said, ‘I’ve been talking to Jack about you this week. He told me that you’d been put in charge until he came along. He doesn’t give praise lightly and he was *very* complimentary about you, Tam.’

‘Oh?’ Tam took a gulp of her drink and tried to look unbothered, but she wondered what else he had said about her.

‘He said you cared about people. He likes that. He’s always seen kindness as a strength, not a weakness like some that I’m sure we have both worked with over time. Anyway, if Jack said you were exceptional then he meant it.’

‘How long have you been together, Anna?’

‘Eh?’ Anna’s eyebrows rose so far up, they almost lodged in the light fittings. Then she laughed. ‘You’ve totally got the wrong end of the stick there, love. We hit it off when we worked together, but only as friends. We had quite a bit in common, going through divorces at the same time. Me and Leo – it was good, then it wasn’t any more. But Rosella chewed Jack up like a combine harvester.’

Tam leaned forward, eager for details.

‘Even clever, intelligent people like Jack can find themselves in the thick of an unhealthy relationship, wondering how they got there. Sometimes you don’t see the goalposts shifting until it’s almost too late.’

Tam knew that – the same had happened to YorkMart.

‘Is that what happened to you too?’ she asked Anna.

‘Not me. Leo and I just grew apart. We split, it was hard but right. My divorce was a walk in the park compared with Jack’s. He was successful, his wife was certainly that, but she didn’t want him to be more successful than she was and competition like that in a marriage . . . well, it’s a blood-red flag, isn’t it? As you’ll know, I’m sure, a good couple will encourage each other to shine and grow. They don’t want to change each other, they don’t want to fix what isn’t broken. They cheer you on, focus on the good that you are. And you’re allowed to disagree on things without them trampling you into the ground. I’ve learned this over the years, Tam, and I wouldn’t settle for anything less.’

Tam nodded. ‘Of course, me too,’ she said. Harris had been happy for all her various successes, it was just that he didn’t want to see her advancing beyond her capabilities or, as he put it, ‘getting above herself’ and then falling from grace like Idle Dick or Martin Middlewood had. He absolutely had her back. And from what Anna was telling her, Jack did too.

She’d been working closely with him that week and seeing him as if with a different pair of eyes. He might have been a ‘hatchet man’ but his weapon didn’t fall in the wrong places. He’d shared his detailed plans for

the company with her based on what he'd learned about it from all the info he'd harvested and from her more personal – if rash – insight. He was intent on shifting people around to where they would perform best and wanted her to rebalance the work–life expectations, because at present some pockets of YorkMart demanded blood in exchange for a pay packet. He had told her in the lift that he was on the same page as her and it hadn't been BS. He knew that people drove the business and he wanted to get the best out of them, through being transparent, consistent, and respecting every individual in the company, from the cleaners to the heads of departments, for their contribution.

'The years since I saw you have made me a much stronger person,' continued Anna. 'I'm kind of grateful for any crap, if you know what I mean.'

'You were always strong,' said Tam honestly. 'Much stronger than I ever was.'

Anna laughed at that. 'I don't think so. I was vulnerable, just hiding behind a brash front, but you . . . you were driven and had a style all of your own. And I know that you were at odds with where you came from, but you were content in your own skin and I envied that. You knew what you wanted to do with your life. I might have convinced you that I did too, but I didn't back then. Not really.'

That threw Tam. She'd been truly taken in by Anna then, fooled by her facade of self-worth. And that was weird, seeing herself through her friend's eyes. Enlightening, actually.

Anna was rolling something around in her mind, Tam could tell from her expression, and so she had to ask the question.

'What is it?'

'I know it's been ten years but it threw me when I first saw you in the restaurant. You looked like you but also . . . not, if that makes any sense. I always knew you'd end up in a high-powered position, but I imagined you in orange suits, bright green, smelling of that lovely flowery perfume. You were always so unique and quirky – *exceptional*, as Jack said. Please don't tell me one of those frogs stamped all that out of you.'

'Don't be silly.' Tam smiled, but it was the one that made her look as if she had wind again.

Back home, Tam took off her jacket to hang it up in the wardrobe and the blandness of her clothes in there hit her as if she were seeing them for the first time. She remembered then telling Anna years ago she would never own a single item of black clothing. She'd arrived for her first day at YorkMart in a kick-ass red suit, coordinating Mary Jane shoes and her beloved Ruby Woo on her lips. She rocked up in reception so bright she could have been seen from the International Space Station. Her boss's first words to her were 'You look as if you mean business, Mrs,' and she'd beamed, because she did. Now, all that was staring back at Tam from her wardrobe was a dull, drab wall, as unexceptional as it was possible to be, give or take the Louboutins.

She remembered the shirt she had that made her look like a Piet Mondrian artwork and the lime blouse with the long collar. She'd stood out from the crowd back then. Stood out enough for a banker to be attracted to her four years ago, drawn to her colourful energy. At least, that's what she'd always presumed. So why had their coming together marked the start of the colours in her wardrobe fading to this plain, plain, plain?

Chapter 12

At Sunday lunch the next day, Tam announced that she wanted to add a last-minute guest to the wedding breakfast.

‘Who?’ asked her mother, wrinkling up her nose in incredulity.

‘An old friend from uni. You remember Anna, the one who looked Swedish?’

‘Ah yes, I remember *that one*,’ replied her father in a way that suggested his memories of her were pronounced but not pleasant. There had been no need for that comment. Anna had been her usual wonderful, friendly self when she’d visited and was certainly more warmly polite to them than they had been to her, but they’d marked her according to her accent, her background. Tam recalled that every time she said ‘Tam’, her mother had embarrassingly corrected it to ‘Tamantha’. But Anna had been equally mortified at her own mum’s behaviour when Tam had gone to her home in Bolton. *We aren’t friends because of our families*, Anna had said at the time, *we’re friends in spite of them*. Neither girl was the sum of her parents – thank the Lord.

‘We’ve finalised all the seating plans,’ said Davina with a huff, as if there was no possible way of making any changes. Tam thought they would have unfinalised them if she’d wanted to bring Jack Cesaroni along. What a thought. Jack Cesaroni, who thought she was *exceptional*.

‘So how much notice have they given you in your job then, Tamantha?’ asked Jame, gearing up to gloat.

Tam delivered her line as matter-of-factly as she could.

‘They haven’t, actually, I’ve been promoted.’

Her brother’s expression morphed into that of a smacked cod.

Tam couldn’t resist giving them more. ‘The MD said I am exceptional.’

‘Exceptional?’ Hellen’s face wrinkled up. ‘What on earth is he talking about?’

‘Sure he didn’t say “questionable”?’ And Harris guffawed at his own wit.

Before Tam could respond, someone spoke up for her. It should have been Harris, but it was Meredith. ‘He must really value you, Tamantha,’ she

said in her wavery, nervous voice.

‘Oh shut up, Meredith. You probably don’t even know what it means,’ said Jame, with a bark of rude laughter that withered her. ‘Oh, by the way, I’ve been nominat—’

‘I want to hear more about Tamantha’s promotion,’ said Meredith, cutting him off, and everyone around the table turned to her in surprise. This was the first time they had ever heard her stand her ground.

‘Thank you, Meredith,’ said Tam, happily supplying the info while trying not to register the same shock as everyone else about Meredith’s worm-turn. ‘I have my old job back with elevated duties in assisting the MD . . . with a very nice pay rise thrown in.’

‘I see.’ Davina’s tone was tight as she flashed her eyes to her son, who clearly hadn’t put her right about his future wife having the affront to continue pursuing a career. Tam had no intention of following suit with Davina or her own mother, who had both given up their jobs as soon as the pregnancy test showed a positive reading.

‘And I would like to add my friend to the reception,’ said Tam. ‘I can ring the venue myself and—’

‘As Davina says, we can’t add people, the table plans are all complete,’ said Samantha adamantly. ‘Don’t interfere at this stage.’

‘Please no wedding talk,’ said Jame, feigning a yawn. ‘As I was saying, I’ve been nominated for an award . . .’

Later, when Tam was loading up the dishwasher, Meredith came through with a pile of crockery. She smiled at Tam and Tam was reminded of how pretty she was. When her brother first brought Meredith to meet them, Tam had thought then he was punching far above his weight. Not that Meredith could compete with him in the job stakes when she was a receptionist in a doctors’ surgery and Jame was the top medic on the planet – at least, that’s what he believed. Meredith had oozed a sweet, if quiet, charm and Tam had hoped it would soften her brother. But it hadn’t; instead, every time she came over, it was as if a little more of her had drained away. It wasn’t Tam’s place to say it, but now they were alone, she really wanted to scream at Meredith to run for the hills away from them all. But Meredith stole the words from her mouth.

‘I think you’re more invisible than even I am here, Tam,’ she said, handing over the plates, with a smile that was really anything but a smile.

That evening, in Harris’s car, as he dropped her off at home, Tam asked a question she hadn’t asked before.

‘What is it that you saw in me that made you want to spend the rest of your life with me?’

Harris huffed impatiently. He wasn’t one for talking feelings.

‘What on earth are you asking that for?’

Because this week has made me think too much, she didn’t say.

‘Humour me, Harris.’

‘I don’t know. You’re attractive, bright. And the more I got to know you, I could see that we were a match.’

‘A match?’ A bark of laughter from her, but one without much humour.

‘Like a lab experiment?’

‘You know what I mean. We are both ambitious, driven. We would have a good life together, solvent, comfortable. I knew we had all the potential to fit together as life partners.’

‘Is that why you fell in love with me?’

‘Of course. And I knew that we’d be on the same page when our children came along.’

Her ears pricked up at that.

‘We haven’t decided if we’re having them, have we?’

‘I know, but . . . it’s expected, isn’t it, surely?’

Tam’s eyes rounded.

‘Expected?’ *By whom,* she didn’t ask, although she knew the answer to that one.

‘Natural, then.’

‘And would I be *expected* to be the one to give up my career to look after them?’

Harris gave a trill of laughter. ‘Well, it could hardly be me, could it?’

She wasn’t sure if it was that trill or his words that irked her more. They’d have a row if she continued with this line, so she changed tack.

‘It’s been a strange week. I just wanted to hear something settling.’

‘Okay, it was a relief to find someone to plan a future with. And the cherry on the cake was that our families get on so well. It was perfect. That okay for you?’

‘Thank you, that’s nice.’ She smiled and then kissed him goodbye. He didn’t want to come in, he had some prep to do for the morning. They’d have all the time in the world to spend with each other soon anyway, when they lived together.

Later, she lay awake, revisiting his words, which had initially made her glow, but the glow was fading quickly the more she looked at it. *It was perfect, he said, not you, not YOU were perfect.* And that word ‘potential’, it was what one might think of a house that needed to be moulded and shaped because it wasn’t liveable as it was. And he said that it was a relief to find *someone* . . . did he mean by that *anyone*? Anyone who might fit his list of prerequisites? She rolled over in bed trying to escape all the questions missiling into her brain, but they wouldn’t leave her alone.

Nowhere in what he said were the words that he fancied her, wanted to rip off her clothes, wanted to make her happy and feel valued and treasured, because that’s what she felt about him and would have said as much if he had asked her why she wanted to spend the rest of her life with him.

Chapter 13

JUNE

Tam dipped her roller into the postbox-red paint and then applied it to the wall.

‘Oh now that is superb. That is BOLD,’ she said. ‘Well done, Anderson.’

‘I learned from the best,’ said Anna, giving her a wink.

‘I’m enjoying myself,’ said Tam, who hadn’t thought she’d ever be painting walls in shades like this again. Harris would spontaneously combust if she suggested a variation on boring beige. She’d work on him. After all, marriage was about accommodating and respecting the other person’s choices as well as your own.

‘How are you feeling about the wedding?’ asked Anna, applying her own roller to the opposite wall. ‘And please don’t apologise again for me not being able to go to the reception, it’s fine, I totally understand. But no one is going to stop me coming to the church and seeing you in that gorgeous dress.’

Tam was still annoyed that Anna wouldn’t be able to be squashed on to someone’s table, all because Davina had to be in control and refused to bend even an inch on anything once she had made her mind up. No wonder Harris’s father had ended up running away from her many years ago.

‘You must be getting really excited.’ Anna’s voice pulled her back from the rhythmic roll of the paint across the walls and she startled a little.

‘Yes, I am,’ replied Tam, but she wasn’t. Maybe she might have been had she had some involvement in all the arrangements, because that’s surely where all the excitement was. Maybe it would have meant more if she and Harris had eloped? Said their vows to each other in front of two witnesses that they’d dragged in off the street?

It wasn’t just that, though, and she couldn’t say, not even to Anna. It was Jack Cesaroni: he had put a spanner in the wedding works. He was on her mind too much, she enjoyed being in his company too much. Ever since

the lift incident, she had begun to see him in a light she really didn't want to see him in. Work was where she was happiest, especially now Anna was on board and they met up almost every lunchtime. She had only seen Natasha once recently – at her parents' last Sunday lunch, but Natasha had her other friends anyway whom she seemed to prefer. Tam wasn't even sure if Natasha had noticed they got together less and less these days . . . Regardless, Tam had no plans to introduce Anna to her. She didn't think they'd get on.

YorkMart was thriving under Jack's leadership. Last week, he had gathered the whole company together into the main atrium for a briefing and given a rousing speech about how they had, for too long, been concentrating on putting on a showy front when it was the core that needed attention. They were going back to the fundamental values that had been the basis of YorkMart's success and every cog, every spring and wheel had a critical role, and Jack would make sure that every person who worked for him would be valued as such. Jack really would have been a smash in a Roman Senate. He was part Italian, maybe one of his ancestors had been there. He'd even look good in a toga. And once or twice she had wondered what he would look like without a toga. Private thoughts, not dangerous, just head junk, never said aloud.

Jack spoke to cleaners with as much warmth and respect as he conversed with managers, clerks, members of the public and press. His charm was no veneer, it was bone-deep. And he'd made good on his promises. Olek was running Finance and Sheila was heading up HR – though she'd been terrified she didn't have the ability, she'd been doing it informally for too long. The temperature had risen by degrees; Tam felt it every time she walked in through the front doors. People seemed happier than they had done for a long time. It was like the glory days again.

When they had been out shopping one lunch hour, Anna had dragged her over to the MAC counter and bought her a Ruby Woo lipstick, and she wondered if she'd ever dare wear it again – at work, if not at home. She had recently bought a shirt in Battenberg-icing bright yellow and Jack had commented on it, told her she had cheered up the office walking in like sunshine personified. He really did know what to say to spin her brain. The colour had seeped into her skin and enlivened her insides, giving her some energy of old. She felt like the equivalent of YorkMart, slowly reconstituting, returning to where she should be.

But also it worried her because ever since the lift, she'd felt as if she had a big spoon inside her head, stirring her up. Life was less complicated before Jack had said she was 'exceptional' and she'd had the affront to believe that she might be someone who was. The word certainly fitted him, *he* was beyond exceptional. He was smart without being superior, professional without being arrogant, kind without being patronising. She was confused by her changed feelings for him and however much she tried to tell herself they were nothing more than respect for someone likeable and honourable, her bumpy heartbeat when she was in his presence said otherwise.

Anna rested her roller in the tray and said with a sincere and soft smile, 'You know you can talk to me if you ever need to, don't you?'

'Of course.' Tam pushed out her best brave smile. Even with the gap of all those years, Anna knew her, knew there was something amiss. 'Wedding nerves,' Tam said. 'Our mothers want it to go without a hitch, so the pressure is on.'

'Have you told them about the dress?' Anna asked.

'Nope,' said Tam. 'It will be a surprise – a statement, that the bride has some importance, some say in her own day.'

After all, it was just a dress. It wasn't as if she was going to ring up the caterers and change the *buuurrrfff* to lamb or replace all the olivine bridesmaids' dresses with fluorescent orange.

It was just a dress.

Chapter 14

THE WEEK BEFORE THE WEDDING

Three nights before Tam's big day, she and Anna went to Wagamama's just outside Meadowhall for cherry syrup gin and noodles.

'This has to be the most low-key hen night I've ever been to,' said Anna, chinking her glass against Tam's.

'I didn't want one,' replied Tam. It was a lie, she really did, with a group of mates all wearing T-shirts with the bride's face on them. She wanted to dance on a table and do a conga around a nightclub and sing 'Agadoo' and push pineapples and shake trees with a posse of girls just like Anna, but there was no one. She'd swerved having a hen-night dinner with Natasha, who had intended to swell the numbers with the three witches: the braggy one whose husband had made it big with solar panels, Politics Penny and the other who looked Tam up and down all the time as if she were a human barcode scanner. Oh, and Kärèn with her umlaut and grave accent.

'I still feel bad about—'

'Tam, stop,' said Anna, holding up her palm to stem the apology. 'I'll be there at the wedding, at the back so I don't give your parents a coronary that a Lancastrian has dared to attend. But I do have a rather natty hat. In Battenberg colours, for a sort of subdued protest.'

Tam sniggered. 'It is so good to have you back in my life.'

'I feel the same.' Anna squeezed her hand. 'I confess, I was a bit worried when I first saw you. You looked so . . . changed, but you haven't, not on the inside, and that's the most important thing.'

'I looked you up online a few times,' Tam confessed. 'I was frightened to contact you in case you'd changed too much for us to have anything in common any more.'

'I got a bit lost for a while,' said Anna, 'and I'm figuring you did too.' Tam smiled benignly. She wished Anna had been able to meet Harris. She'd seen pics and said he was very good-looking: tall, fair, even adding that he

would have made a great Prince Charming in a panto. He'd said he was too busy, though, and Tam tried to bat the suspicion away that he might be preordained to disapprove of her formidable friend.

'It's not too late to back out,' Anna joked, as she sipped her drink.

'Don't be silly,' Tam said with a laugh that was a little too bright, a little too forced. No, it was just wedding nerves. But sometimes she wondered why the closer the big day came, the more they were starting to feel too much like doubts.

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Chapter 15

TWO DAYS BEFORE THE WEDDING

On the last working day before her wedding, Tam stayed late to tie up all her ends before packing up the presents that people had brought for her. There were loads, and some of the messages in the cards really had a sweet punch:

Be Happy and THANK YOU for everything you've done for me – Sheila.

Congratulations to you both. Hope you are as brilliant a wife as you are a boss.

*Your groom is a really lucky man. You're a star – Jason
(Grocery)*

The whole Operations department had gathered at her desk that afternoon with a cake from the artisan bakery around the corner. It was a cream sponge, decorated in pink-and-yellow Battenberg colours because someone had tipped them the wink they were her favourite. A plastic bride and groom stood on top, the groom so much taller than the bride, which was exactly how she was going to look in her lace pumps. Tam had got quite emotional making a speech thanking them all. She'd noticed, though, that Jack hadn't been there to witness her having a sob. But then, he'd seen too much of her underbelly since he joined the company, so she was glad he wasn't there.

She was just about to leave when Jack raced in through the far doors.

'Thank goodness you're still here,' he said, breathless as if he'd been running a distance. 'I've got something for you.'

He flew into his office and came out with a large square box, a silver ribbon around it. He set it down on her desk and said, 'A wedding present

from me.'

'Oh, you shouldn't have,' she replied quickly, as her heartbeat seemed to double in speed. 'I presumed that the presents I got were partly from you anyway.'

'Wrong,' he said, 'I got my own. But I will warn you, it's not conventional.'

He nodded at her to open it. She lifted the top off the box and inside was a felted Siamese cat, about half the size of Walter, but looking so much like him that she gasped in delighted shock.

'A lady in Scotland makes them. I remember you telling me in the lift about Walter so I hoped you might like this. I had to go hunting on social media to find out what he looked like. Luckily, you had quite a lot of photos of him on Facebook,' said Jack. 'No Wiki page, though, so I win.'

He smiled and she felt a series of small bombs set off inside her. *Just gratitude*, she thought, that's all it was, this warm feeling swirling inside her – gratitude for caring, for taking the time to find something special. Something she loved already. Something that Harris wouldn't want on show in their new home because . . . *aren't you a bit too old for toys?* She heard his voice and shooed it away.

'I don't know what to say,' she mumbled, afraid she might cry again and she'd done enough of that today.

'That you like it is enough.'

'I really do.' She took a deep breath to counteract the vortex of emotion rising within her.

'I know it's not exactly a present for both of you but I thought you'd have enough toasters and John Lewis vouchers. I wanted to give you something . . .'

He tailed off and grinned and she grinned back because they both knew what the missing word was.

'For an exceptional woman,' he went on and she wished he hadn't, she really did.

'Be happy, Tam.' And he turned away, leaving her trying to quell a whirl of thoughts she didn't want to have at all.

Chapter 16

WEDDING EVE

On the night before the wedding, Tam was alone in her house wondering if it was normal to feel numb rather than excited. Her mother was at the family home with Davina, both of them busy going over the many plans for the next day. Tam had put them both off – and Natasha – from inspecting the dress hanging up in her bedroom. The next time they would see her would be at the church. The bridesmaids were having their hair and make-up done at the Bullivant family home where Natasha could direct, boss, dictate. Tam had insisted she get ready alone, citing that it was a bride's prerogative to surprise.

Harris obviously couldn't see her tonight, because it wasn't the done thing to see the bride before the wedding. He did ring, though, to say that he was looking forward to their big day, which is what she needed to hear. Oh and . . . he knew it was tradition for the bride to run late but could she please not, because it would make his mother anxious if the timings were out. Apparently, anxiety could irritate her bladder. Tam promised that she wouldn't, but it was a flat end to the call. The last words should have been 'I love you', not 'possible urinary infection'.

She put down the phone and it hit her that this would be her last night as a single woman living in her single house. Tomorrow, she would be sleeping in a five-star honeymoon suite in a hotel, and the day after she would be in Harris's apartment and her little mews house would then be going up for sale along with all her memories of moving in here, painting the walls in crazy shades, of watching box sets on her massive squashy lime-green sofa with Walter asleep on her knee.

She put her phone on the charging station and picked up the felted cat that she'd put on the shelf. She cuddled it and wished the real Walter was still here. She wanted another cat so much, but Harris didn't want to have hairs all over his clothes. Plus they made him sneeze. Something else she would have to compromise on. She would have to settle for felted Walter

then, and she would make sure that he was on display in their home, however much Harris moaned about it.

A knock on the door interrupted her thoughts and Tam found Meredith on her doorstep. She looked pale and, despite it being a warm summer evening, she was shivering. Tam brought her inside and Meredith's eyes roved over the space, from the huge almost fluorescent sofa to the ornate mini chandelier in the lounge, two of the last vestiges of how things once were.

'This has changed from the last time I came here,' Meredith said. 'It used to be like walking into a rainbow.'

'I've got it ready to sell,' explained Tam. 'Buyers like a blank canvas. Please, have a seat.'

Meredith perched nervously. Tam waited for her to say what she was here for, but no sooner had her bottom touched the cushion than she stood up.

'I shouldn't be here. Not today. I'm so sorry. I should go.'

'Meredith, sit down and talk to me,' Tam said firmly, pressing her down on to the squishy sofa. What on earth could she want? *A riddle wrapped in a mystery inside an enigma packed in a puzzle and tied with a brainteaser bow*, as one of her lecturers at uni used to say.

Tam wasn't expecting her next words, which came out in such a hurried jumble one might have been excused for thinking they were unauthorised lyrics to 'Flight of the Bumblebee'.

'I'm leaving Jame. Tomorrow. After your wedding. He doesn't know, he doesn't think there's anything wrong with our relationship.' She gave a small laugh at the absurdity of that. 'I wanted to apologise to you in advance in case I don't see you again. I didn't want to spoil your day but the timings line up on my side, so it has to be tomorrow. I think you'll understand. You've always been so kind to me and I'm really sorry about this. Oh my, I don't know what I was thinking of, coming here.'

Tam reached for her hands, which were shaking and cold to the touch.

'Oh Meredith, I get it, I really do,' she said gently, because she was glad that Meredith was escaping the whale's mouth before it finally swallowed her; it had been chewing the life out of her for too long. 'Do you have somewhere to go?'

Meredith nodded. 'Yes, it's all sorted. I'm staying near my sister in Derbyshire.'

‘Good for you.’

Meredith laughed in great relief, and Tam saw a flicker of something, like a speck of life, in her eyes.

‘You know, I used to sing around the house,’ Meredith said. ‘Singing was my happy thing. Looking back, I think that was the start of it. Jame asking me to stop because the noise was annoying him. I’ve been singing like a lark since I decided to leave him.’

Tam made Meredith a coffee and she sat there drawing the warmth from the mug, opening up her heart. Tam’s brother really was the most awful bully. She was glad Meredith had woken up to it.

Eventually, Meredith stood up. ‘I’ve said too much, I should go. Thank you for listening to me. You have no idea how glad I am you understand. I don’t think anyone else will miss me on Sundays. I don’t think I care, though.’

At the door, Tam gave her a firm hug, but she had to ask. ‘What was it that finally made you make the change, Meredith?’

‘That day at your parents’ house, when I said to you that you were more invisible than me. It was like I was seeing myself, my situation, for the first time . . . in you. I knew then I had to start making plans.’ Meredith took her hand and squeezed it. ‘Don’t fade your colours for anyone, Tam,’ she said fiercely, and with that she turned and left.

Tam closed the door and sagged against it, her back pressed into the wood, turning Meredith’s words over in her brain. Her relationship with Harris was nothing like Meredith’s with Jame. Harris only wanted the best for her, he always had her best interests at heart. He suggested improvements to her for *her* benefit. They weren’t the same, they really weren’t.

Chapter 17

THE WEDDING DAY

The sunshine pouring through the gap in the curtains had awoken Tam before her alarm did, but she hadn't slept well and the make-up lady had her work cut out with those tired eyes. It was a perfect day for the perfect wedding. And Tam looked like the perfect bride in her beautiful dress. She overrode the directive Natasha had sent through the night before to the make-up artist of 'dewy and modest'; she wanted to wear the brightest red lipstick in the box and for her hair to be a magnificent cloud, not straightened to a sheet. She wanted to feel like the version of Tam Remington when she was at her happiest for this – the happiest of days.

But she didn't feel happy. She felt wrong. And it wasn't wedding nerves. Thoughts had been tumbling around in her head all night – Meredith's words about her colours fading, Anna knowing that something wasn't right with her, but mainly Jack Cesaroni. His present to her had been ironic because he had put a cat among the pigeons in her life. She tried to shake him out of her head, she had no right thinking about him today.

She and her father in the Rolls were only a couple of minutes late, due to some workmen dealing with a leak on a street, so Davina's own waterworks shouldn't be affected. She'd waited for her dad to tell her she looked beautiful, but he hadn't.

The bridesmaids were outside the church and not even the sharp morning sunlight could add any interest to the olivine shade of their dresses. When she emerged from the car, Meredith smiled at her and mouthed the words, 'You look gorgeous.' Natasha didn't say anything, but her face said everything.

The organ music started and Tam began to walk in her lace pumps down the plush red carpet of the aisle. Tam noticed Anna sitting at the back in her Battenberg hat and she really needed her smile to fortify her. Ahead was her groom in a beautifully cut morning suit and just for a moment she imagined Jack Cesaroni in his stance, his wide shoulders and strong arms,

his long legs, his lopsided smile as his eyes turned to find her. But there was no smile on Harris's face, no joy. Instead, all she could see was judgement. She could read in his expression that he did not like her dress, her hair, or her bright lipstick. And as her father pressed her hand into Harris's, she saw in the stiffness of his back that there was no bend in any part of him.

‘Dearly beloved . . .’

‘How could you turn up like *that*? In that dress, with that hair?’ Harris growled, the words squeezed through his furious lips for her ears only. ‘And I *told* you not to be late!’

Tam stared into his eyes, inches from hers, as with those words came a clear and certain realisation. She was not enough for this man, and wouldn't be until she was totally squashed out of shape to fit his list of ‘acceptables’. She was not loved and valued as she deserved to be because she was – to borrow another man's word – *exceptional*. The word had lodged in her head with good reason, because she was worth much more than what lay on the other side of her wedding vows – and the old Tam Remington still residing inside her knew that. She had felt sorry for Meredith without realising they were the same, crushed under the expectations of others. And it would never get any better for her, which is why she had cheered Meredith on for making the decision to break free. But it was way too late for Tam now she was here, at the altar, at her wedding, with two hundred plus people watching her . . . wasn't it? It would be madness to do anything other than go for damage limitation, apologise for daring to be herself, follow the script, say ‘I do’ even though her heart was screaming ‘I don't’.

In that moment, she felt like a Jack-in-the-box that had been pushed down until the lid had almost closed, but just in time she had sprung up with her Ruby Woo big smile and mad hair. And she wouldn't be pushed down ever again.

Without another thought, Tam turned to Meredith, handed over her bouquet and smiled at her in a way that said everything, then in her lovely lace pumps she walked back down the aisle and out of the church into the light.

Chapter 18

SIX MONTHS LATER

What a wonderful Christmas present for YorkMart – it had just slid into fourth place in the supermarket leader board behind the three massive boys in the industry, which was cause for a big celebration. Every worker in the company was to get a new year bonus in their wage packet as a token of appreciation. YorkMart was back to its prime. And Tam Remington was on her way back to hers.

After the champagne bottles had been emptied in the boardroom, Jack asked Tam if he could snatch a few words with her, in his office, away from everyone. He'd been kind, these past months. Told her if she ever needed time off, or anything at all, she just had to ask, and while she hadn't taken him up on that she appreciated it and knew he meant it. He'd left her to plough her energies where they needed to go, he'd left her to heal and mend, but she'd always felt that he was there hovering nearby, in case she needed more from him than reports about industrial growth.

They took the lift down to the first floor. She didn't mind them these days, not since Jack had had a new system put in. Things Jack had a hand in tended to run without a hitch. Plus she had lost her anxious air, the tenseness she'd carried in her bones. She hadn't realised it was present until it wasn't any more. She hadn't needed to use her inhaler in months. Six months, to be exact.

Thirteen, twelve, eleven . . . The lift made a smooth descent, then stopped abruptly and the emergency lights came on.

Jack and Tam looked at each other.

'I don't believe it,' she said. And she laughed. She laughed like she hadn't laughed in a long while and it was a sobering thought how long that was.

Work had been her salvation these past weeks. Work and Anna. Natasha no longer spoke to her, and Tam wasn't sure if that was such a bad thing. It might not even have been a friendship in the true sense of the word,

now she looked back – more like an attempt to fill a lonely void in her life that a pal should occupy.

Today marked exactly six months to the date since Tam had turned on her heel and walked back down the aisle, a bride unwed. Things might have been very different if she had worn the ‘right’ gown, if she hadn’t wanted to have a little of the day for herself. It hadn’t been a lot to ask, but it still turned out to be too much. If she’d worn the Abominable Snowman dress, been less *Tam*, she would be married now, living in Harris’s flat with all her bright accoutrements packed away in boxes probably never to see the light of day again. And more and more of Tam Remington would have found its way into those boxes, stuck forever in the shadows. She had wondered whether the old Tam had insisted she stick to her guns on her dress in order to provoke the scene in the church that made her rise up in magnificent rebellion. Madness to think of herself rescuing herself, of course . . . but still she wondered.

Only her father had been in touch since; he’d rung to tell her what a disgrace she was, upsetting everyone’s day like that. And the expense. Did she realise how it looked? She had put the phone down on him. Davina had fired off a stiff note to demand that the engagement ring be returned as it was her grandmother’s, but it had already been on its way back to her.

‘Are you okay?’ Jack asked.

‘I’m fine,’ said Tam. ‘I know it must be a blip with the power rather than the maintenance—’

‘I didn’t mean just about being stuck in the lift,’ said Jack. ‘I mean *you*.’

Even in the darkened space, the emergency light glowing softly, his energy beamed like a torch, a warm nourishing light. A man who encouraged others to shine. Who wanted her to shine. He had given her free rein to embark on a dedicated pastoral programme. Colleagues with any worries outside of work were assisted; help and resources were on hand for those who needed them, especially when family problems or aged parent problems called for pliancy – because without the ability to bend, things tended to break. She, above everyone, knew that.

‘I’m good,’ she said. She smiled at him with her full Ruby Woo lips, the same colour as her shoes, which shouldn’t have gone with her bright-green suit, but somehow it all worked because inner and outer confidence had a tendency to weave magic.

She had a new set of friends outside of work, because she and Anna had met some great women in the 'Fun Fit Chicks' classes they'd signed up for. They were the sort of women any self-respecting bride would welcome on her hen night, 'Agadoo'-ing around a dance floor, wearing T-shirts with her face on them. Hopefully one day, anyway. They were kind and fun and glorious. In such a short space of time, Tam was finally surrounded by the sort of people she would have picked as family if she'd had a choice.

'I'm good, really,' she said, because that look on his face said he really wanted to believe that was the truth. 'And I have you to partly thank for that.'

She didn't say she also had him partly to curse for messing up her head and changing her life out of all recognition. Though, if it had been a curse, it was certainly one of the better kinds.

'You know, Tam, while I have you to myself, we couldn't have turned the company around if you hadn't stepped in, running your covert operations and really setting us up for success when you did. I want you to know that when I move on, I will do everything I possibly can to make sure that you are running the place.'

Her breath caught. 'You're moving on?'

His soft eyes met hers and he smirked. 'No, but it was nice to see the fear in your face that I might be.'

She smiled. She smiled a lot these days and it was often to do with being around Jack. And she sometimes liked to daydream that Jack's perma-smile was something to do with her. Fat chance.

'You are meant for the top seat, Tam. I have every faith in you.'

'I know, I'm *exceptional*,' she said, doing her best to play it cool, which was pretty difficult with her heart bouncing around inside her like an excited puppy's.

'You are much more than that,' Jack said. 'Do you remember the last time we were trapped in a lift?'

She could hardly forget it. He had awoken something inside of her that day. Someone. Herself.

'I had to keep asking you questions to distract you.'

'Yes, I—'

The lift suddenly bucked hard and Jack reached out to steady her, hold her. Just like last time. But unlike last time she made no attempt to move away, and he didn't seem to be in a rush to let go either. They stood there in

the semi-dark, still, hardly daring to breathe and break the moment. She felt his mouth against her hair and she inhaled his scent as he pressed her ever so slightly closer, then closer still, his arms tightening with slow deliberate deliciousness. She hoped those lift doors would stay closed all Christmas.

‘Miss Remington . . .’ He whispered her name in her ear, and she thought it was a good job he had a firm grip on her because her legs felt awfully crumbly. ‘If we ever get out of here, there’s something I’d like to discuss with you about your future. Are you free for lunch? Or dinner? Or both?’

She lifted her head, this rejuvenated version of Tam Remington who was always pretty exceptional, although it had taken the kindness and insight of the man who sounded like a pizza to make her start realising it again. She had no need to waste her words. She simply leaned in, and he tasted the answer on her full, gloriously unsubtle Ruby Woo lips.

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

I often write about women who are due a renaissance because there are too many who do not value themselves for all they do for others, for the wonderful selfless people they are. Women have a tendency to put themselves last in their list of priorities, they often run on empty batteries because they feel guilty taking the time out to recharge, they are afraid to say no, they keep too much toxicity in their lives because they're too nice to expel it. If you're nodding reading this, then take my advice: follow your intuitions (which get stronger as we get older). Have only people around you who lift you up, who add to your smiles . . . and be your own best friend. I am lucky to have many fabulous women in my life who have my back, as I have theirs, and inspire me to write about the precious worth of friendship. This year, thank you in particular to Phillipa Ashley, Veronica Henry, Debbie Johnson and Jane Costello, the best of authors and the best of pals.

I am blessed to have a career I love with an amazing team of people behind me, especially my agent Lizzy Kremer and Maddalena Cavaciuti and everyone at David Higham Associates. And it's been fantastic to work with Amazon on *Lift Me Up*: particularly Victoria Oundjian and Jenni Davis. And to the brilliant Maisie Lawrence I say, thank you for inviting me on board. It's been a pleasure to catch up with you again and long may your star continue to rise and shine.

Dear readers, I hope you enjoy this story, which has the underestimated power of love and kindness at its heart. The world will always be richer for having both of those qualities in abundance.

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23 December

*Yesterday is history,
tomorrow is a mystery
but today is a gift*

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Chapter 1

The snowflakes started to fall on the windscreen as soon as Vincent Diamond – of Diamond Service Taxis – had turned onto the A7501 towards Whitby, as if they had somehow been triggered by his change in direction. Within the minute, he'd had to notch up his wipers from the intermittent setting to the steady swipe to maintain his vision of the road. He couldn't remember there being any warning of this on the weather forecast, which he checked every morning, especially when he had a long journey in the diary. And super especially when he had a long journey to make in the bleak midwinter.

The drop in temperature inside his cab was probably his imagination working overtime in response to the sudden snowfall but he reached over to tweak up the heating all the same.

'You warm enough back there?' he called over his shoulder to his passenger.

'Yes, thank you,' she replied.

Miss Elizabeth Dudley, whom he was chauffeuring from Reading to Durham. Her voice matched the rest of her: ladylike, cultured, honeyed. She was probably the most beautiful fare he'd had in the back of his cab, and that was saying something as he'd picked up a lot of actresses from theatres in the West End. His eyes flicked up to the rear-view mirror to see her looking out of the window to her side, weighing up this sudden change in weather. Then her mobile phone claimed her attention: no daft ringtone, just a classic brrr-brrr.

She pulled it out of her bag, answered it. 'Hi,' she said. Even with just that short word, the recipient of it must have felt she really wanted to speak to them, Vincent mused. He thought she looked like an Elizabeth. His mum had been an Elizabeth, and his gran, and so he was predisposed to the name being synonymous with lovely women.

She leaned forward to ask him: 'Excuse me, how far are we away from Topston?'

'About two hours, with holiday traffic,' Vincent answered. He didn't say, and the weather, because he presumed this was just a rogue flurry or the weathermen would have said otherwise. Metcheck had given the

forecast as cloudy, rain changing to sleet mid-afternoon, and a constant one centigrade temperature, though on his dashboard it was showing as minus six outside. It wouldn't hold them up, he was sure of it, just a temporary pocket of cold front. He hoped it wouldn't, anyway, for he had to drive back in it as soon as he'd dropped her off on the outskirts of Durham. Topston Manor, one of those piles that made footballers' houses in Alderley Edge look like gate lodges. His old mum, ever the pragmatist, would have looked at the pictures of it and said, 'How much would the window-cleaning bill be for that every month?' God bless her, wherever she was. Looking down at him, no doubt, still worrying about him, still loving him.

'About two hours,' Elizabeth repeated down the phone.

There was a lull while whoever was on the other end of the phone spoke again.

'Well, it is—' Elizabeth attempted to answer but it seems she was interrupted. Another long lull.

'I know you told me to come up before but I couldn't. I had things I needed to do . . . I know it's important I . . . yes, I understand that . . . Gregory, please let me speak, I—'

'Gregory' wasn't letting her get a word in. Vincent gathered he wasn't a happy bunny. He visualised someone that made Darth Vader look like the Dalai Lama.

Vincent's foot pressed gently on the brake. The snowflakes were getting fatter and faster and they'd already started to settle on the road. He turned on the blower because the windscreen was misting up and reducing visibility.

'Gregory, can you just listen to me for a moment, what's the weather like there because here the snow is really bad . . . Oh, you don't have any?'

'Well, that was good, thought Vincent, eavesdropping. Just a localised storm, in that case. It would make its presence known and then melt quickly away, with any luck.

'Yes, I'm sure we'll be there well before seven . . . but I can't help the weather can— Gregory . . . ? Hello, are you still there?'

Gregory clearly wasn't. Elizabeth rang him back but it went to answerphone and she was forced to leave a message.

'Hi, Gregory, it's me. I'm not sure if we got cut off or you'd finished saying what you had to. I'll keep you posted on where we are. See you soon . . . Bye.'

Vincent slowed the car down even further. The wiper blades were operating at full pelt and the snowflakes were as big as pennies. The cars in front of him all had iced roofs and had it gone suddenly darker or was he getting snow-blind?

‘I’m supposed to be at a party at seven,’ said Elizabeth, her words riding on a long drawn-out sigh.

Vincent’s eyes snatched up the time on the dashboard clock: five to three. ‘I’m sure you will be,’ he replied. He wondered if at any point in the conversation Shouty Gregory had told her to be careful and get there when she could – and safely.

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Chapter 2

Jane Wutheridge was glad she'd had the foresight to wear her old snow boots to travel in, not that there was a hint of snow when she left their Derbyshire house but because they were snug and warm and gripped the ground like a limpet. She still called it their house, even though it had been solely hers for just under a year, but it wouldn't be theirs – or rather hers – any longer in less than four weeks, because contracts would soon be exchanged and then completion on the sale of it would follow. They were reliable and safe boots, comfortable, solid as a rock . . . her boots had all the qualities her life was presently lacking.

She hadn't wanted to make this train journey. She wanted Christmas alone, a last one in the rectory before the new owners came in. She was cross she'd been pressured into spending it elsewhere. And the disruption just put the tin hat on things. She wasn't frightened of snow like some old people; she loved it. She and Clifford had taken many winter holidays; in fact, they'd been hundreds of kilometres past the Arctic Circle and then down to Antarctica, where they wanted to go again, but life got in the way of their plans. Or rather death did.

The conductor entered the carriage and stood by the sliding door.

'Can I have everyone's attention, please? Sorry, the tannoy isn't working. We've been informed that we have to divert to Selton. For services west, you need to get off at the next stop, Derringbury, for the connecting train to Eskford. I repeat, we are now no longer calling at Eskford on this train.'

'Chuffing hell,' said the loud man behind Jane, whose voice hadn't dropped below a hundred decibels since he got on. 'One leaf or a snowflake and the trains go to absolute cock in this country.'

The conductor ignored him and announced that they'd be at Derringbury in a few minutes.

Jane reached into her bag for her brown bucket hat. Clifford had bought it for her, one of his last presents. 'I thought it was about time we started buying each other practical things,' he'd said with a twinkle in his eye, though it wasn't as bright a twinkle as the one in the diamond ring he'd tied to the label inside the hat. It was on her finger now. An eternity ring,

even though they knew their time was running out – at least here on earth. But Clifford was that rare being, a scientist who believed in an afterlife and he knew they'd share that eternity. The irony was that she, a creative, a romantic, believed that life, consciousness, everything, ended with the last breath.

Jane put on her gloves and made her way to the storage rack for her suitcase, declining the help of the conductor because she wasn't ready to start playing the old-lady card just yet. She'd packed fairly lightly and luckily had sent the presents on ahead. She hadn't gone over the top with them either, this year, because, for as long as she could remember, she'd spent far too much time trying to match the gift to the person only to get the lazy options in return: chocolates with a suspiciously close sell-by date, a market-tat brooch in a cheap box, a manicure set. She'd had at least ten manicure sets in various forms over the years.

Clifford would have said that this interference in plans constituted an adventure. But Clifford wasn't here to share her fears and take the reins; she was all alone and there was no excitement to be had.

Further down the same train, Frank O'Carroll and his wife, Grace, were preparing to disembark. They should have been getting off at Eskford but as it was having to divert, they'd have to get yet another connecting train – their fourth on this journey. He was beginning to think this trip was cursed from the get-go. Firstly he'd buggered up his ankle and couldn't drive – and Grace didn't have the confidence to drive this far – so the only way they could reach their country cottage getaway was by public transport. Plus the place he really wanted had been double-booked and they'd had to take the option of another which wasn't the cosy, olde-worlde with log-fire one he'd put his deposit on. Mistletoe Nook might have sounded idyllic but the photos showed a modern bungalow full of the brown and orange décor that was a signature of the seventies. At this late stage, it was accept that or nothing, so his hands were tied and not even the part-refund made it sweet. His mum always said bad luck came in threes: more like a hundred and threes, thought Frank as they headed for the storage bay where their two suitcases were situated. Grace hadn't said a word and by not saying anything, she said everything. Frank could feel annoyance pumping out of her pores like toxic fumes from a faulty air vent. She hadn't even wanted to come away for Christmas, he'd been the one to suggest it, push for it, because he knew if they stayed at home, by the new year one of them would

have moved out. A romantic cottage with a log-fire was his last desperate attempt to save their thirty-three-year relationship. The modern substitute cottage wasn't going to have any restorative magic, he just knew it.

The train edged out of the tunnel into a world that seemed much whiter than it had been when they'd entered it. Frank looked through the window at the snow falling hard. The hills in the distance were totally covered and had smudged into the sky.

He turned to Grace.

'It'll be fine, just another blip to test us. We'll be in Eskford in no time and then it's just a short walk to the cottage. I'm not worried. It'll be all the cosier for this messing about.' His smile was bright, covering up the worry he said he didn't have.

Grace didn't look worried at all though, she just looked . . . resigned was the best way of putting it. Whether they reached the cottage and it was warm and inviting or they ended up stuck all Christmas in a train station in the middle of nowhere, he believed she'd wear the same expression.

The train slowed and they passed signs announcing the name of Derringbury station. He spotted a waiting room, thank goodness, because he didn't fancy standing on a freezing, uncovered platform until their connection arrived.

'Can you manage?' he asked his wife who was wrestling with her suitcase handle.

'Of course I can,' she answered him, that ever-present snap in her voice. He wasn't even sure she knew it was there, it had just become her default way of talking to him. The Grace of old would have waved away the booking debacle and be searing his ears with giddy questions: What do you think is the first thing we should do when we get to the cottage? Shall we go to the local pub for tea? Should we get up early to go to the farm shop and buy too much food? Little Miss Chatterbox, he used to call her. These days she only seemed to speak when she needed to and though her incessant talk used to drive him bonkers, he missed it. He missed the old Grace; she was like a shell emptied.

It appeared there were just them and another passenger who were alighting: a small, aged lady had just stepped onto the platform and Frank thought she looked as if she'd climbed out of a Miss Marple book with her slight frame, stompy boots, hat and tweed coat.

Frank helped Grace to ‘mind the gap’ and then he called over to ‘Miss Marple’, pointing at her suitcase.

‘Can I help you with that?’

‘Thank you, that’s very kind, but it’s on wheels and easy to steer.’

He could at least get the door into the waiting room for her. He held it open and she thanked him as she walked through. Grace followed, a heavy dusting of snow on her shoulders and on her long tied-back auburn hair, which melted instantly in the warmth that met them inside.

The first thought that came to Frank was that he’d wandered onto the film set of *Brief Encounter* because, apart from the bulk of a large modern machine for the distribution of hot drinks in the corner, the place couldn’t have had a refurb for decades. It smelt fusty, but in a comforting way, like the smell of old books.

There was a long bench opposite a couple of rusty storage heaters mounted on the wall that were pumping out hot air, effectively too considering how ancient they looked. Grace took a seat near one of them, leaving a gap between her and Jane.

‘Shocking weather, isn’t it?’ Frank said to her.

‘Awful,’ Jane replied. ‘At least it’s nice and warm in here. Are you changing at Eskford as well?’ She really wasn’t sure that she’d done the right thing, getting off here in this tiny station. She should have stayed on until the major junction at Selton and decided what to do from there on. Returning home would have been the most sensible option of all, of course.

‘No, Eskford is our final destination. We’ve booked a cottage. For Christmas.’ Then Frank looked around and spoke to himself, but aloud. ‘There must be some timetable around somewhere.’ Did they still have those in stations? It showed how long it was since he’d been in one that he didn’t know. Maybe paper ones were a thing of the past and everything was on computers and phone apps now, which was all very well until you had a situation like this. His phone was saying there was no internet, no Wi-Fi available. There was a lot to be said for hard copy data. Nothing for it but to wait then.

Frank stood up and went over to the coffee machine. He couldn’t see a coin slot, or prices. He tried his luck, pressed a button that said ‘Hot Chocolate’ and to his surprise, the machine dropped a cup below and obliged him.

‘Blimey. It’s not often you get something for nothing these days. Anyone else want one? Hot chocolate, chicken soup, tea, coffee with or without milk?’ No fancy lattes or flat whites as an offering. There was a small table adjacent with spoons and sugar sachets and paper serviettes. Jane mouthed a silent no-thank-you. ‘Grace?’

‘I don’t want anything if there’s a train due,’ she answered.

‘Well, maybe if you get a drink that’ll hurry the train along. Sod’s law and all that,’ said Frank with a smile that was wasted because she had turned away from him, her eyes instead roving over the flaking vintage green paint of the walls and the intricate, but heavily chipped, ceiling cornice.

He carried the plastic cup back to his seat. He offered his wife the first sip from it but she shook her head. The old Grace would have tried it and claimed it and he’d have laughed and had to get himself another. She could never resist a hot chocolate. He’d bought her a fancy machine to make them a couple of Christmases ago and it was still in the box. He hadn’t encountered the old Grace for years and maybe it was a mistake to think she was still in there somewhere; maybe she had gone forever, leaving only this husk he lived with.

They sat in silence, waiting. Then Grace got up without saying anything and headed towards the door with a toilet sign above it.

‘So where are you travelling to?’ Frank asked, striking up conversation with Miss Marple. He would later be amused when he found out her name was Jane.

‘Lancaster,’ she answered him, with an accompanying sigh.

‘Lancaster?’ Frank puffed out his cheeks. ‘How long is that going to take you?’ He guessed over three hours from here, without hitches and there was a very big hitch outside in the form of all that snow.

‘I don’t even want to think about it,’ said Jane. She really should have gone on to Selton, she felt it more with every minute that passed. There was a large hotel attached to the station that would surely have a vacancy – even at this time of year; a room reserved for emergencies. That was one advantage of being old; people tended to go the extra mile for pensioners.

‘Aren’t there any staff here?’ asked Frank, with a sudden burst of frustration. ‘There should be a stationmaster around. Should we be worried?’ He dropped a small laugh, but it was only half a laugh and it wasn’t a very convincing one at that.

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Note for American readers: *The Happiest Ever After* is published in the United States as *The Accidental Rewrite*.

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Welcome to Spring Hill, home to a square of independent shops and cafes, a thriving local community and nearby the newest venture, Ray's Diner. Here a group of women meet once a week over a cup of something warming.

Amanda is primary carer to her elderly mother and one of the only women in a male-dominated company. Used to being second-best all her life, is this her time to finally break ranks and shine?

Sky works at the repair shop, patching up old teddy bears, and their owners' hearts. But her heart beats for the one man who is strictly off-limits.

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Can these women find the answers to their worries, acceptance, courage, support here? Join them at the same time next week to find out . . .

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR



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Milly Johnson was born, raised and still lives in Barnsley, South Yorkshire. A *Sunday Times* bestseller, she is one of the Top 10 Female Fiction authors in the UK, and has sold millions of copies of her books across the world.

Milly's writing highlights the importance of community spirit and the magic of kindness. Her books inspire and uplift but she packs a punch and never shies away from the hard realities of life and the complexities of relationships in her stories. Her books champion women, their strength and resilience, and celebrate love, friendship and the possibility and joy of second chances and renaissances.

For more information and news, please visit www.millyjohnson.co.uk or (in the US) www.milly-johnson.com.

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